

Note from Brandon Sanderson

In the process of editing any novel, you realize that some scenes just don't work right. There are many reasons for that. While removing such scenes is one of the hardest parts of the book writing process, it's like pruning a tree to allow new parts to 'sprout'. In the end the book gets better.

I have to say, I'm always looking for a way to show scenes like this. These pieces not only reveal what I find interesting, but often contain gems that I would like to share. The moment with Gaul and the bridge in this story is a great example.

The next scene was cut from the Memory of Light, the last book of the Wheel of Time. I must warn you, it includes a lot of characters in the middle of the arcs, so if you don't know about the Wheel of Time, you might get a little lost. I've done my best to make the scene readable on its own, but it's simply not possible to make it completely standalone due to the nature of its origin.

Also, it is not canon for the Wheel of Time. While I really like the way things are going here, our final removal decision required some changes to the Memory of Light text that included the details of this part. There is simply no place for her in the chronology of the last book. Characters will literally be forced to be in two places at the same time. Also, several minor character arcs run differently here, which contradicts the published version of the story.

This scene should not be considered as a replacement for the others. Moreover, this is a chance for me to show you something that has never been published. Think of it as a path that history could have taken but never did.

The thing is this: the enemy uses the Paths to move troops, surprisingly attacking cities. Caemlyn - the capital of Andor, one of the most important cities in the cycle - has recently been captured by an enemy using the Ways.

Our characters decided that cutting off the enemy's ability to use the Paths was vital. They cannot continue to rearm and supply supplies to the armies behind the front lines, so they create a desperate plan. Perrin, with a detachment of elite troops and guides (people using the mystical power of the Wheel of Time), go to the Paths to destroy some of the routes that the enemy walks.

I hope you enjoy this interesting behind-the-scenes material!

Chapter 1

Hammer in hand, Perrin stepped out of the gate and looked around the narrow cobblestone street of Cairhien. It was night, and darkness covered the road, though the lantern that shone through the passage tinted the stones beneath his feet with golden light.

The city stank of people: the smoke from the chimneys, the lingering aroma of powder and perfume, even the smell of the paint that covered the wooden walls of the houses - long dried up and tarnished. Gone was the stench of spoiled food, so familiar to cities. Not a single trickle of it was left in Cairhien now.

At first, a part of him focused on the smoke, but Perrin pushed the fact of it into the back of his mind. Fire is the simplest and often the first signal for the presence of people for wolves.

Passing down the deserted lane, Perrin waved his hand to his group. The air around was still strange. As for Perrin, the noise is another sign of human presence. People often didn't pay attention to how much noise they made. In the forest, man was a thunderous, snorting and grumbling creature. Here in the city, this cacophony was to increase many times over.

And yet, the streets were quiet. Unnaturally quiet. Even at night Cairhien shouldn't be this quiet.

When he reached the beginning of the alley, Perrin peered into the darkness and found the large street he was crossing. To his left was a building on which flared a

banner depicting the lion of Andor and the rising sun of Cairhien. Several people passed by. They smelled of wine and unwashed bodies.

- Where is everyone? asked Arganda, who had slipped in beside Perrin holding the lantern closed.

The first captain of the guard to Aliandre, Queen of Gaeldan, Arganda was a stocky man, thin and lean like a hare. It was a pleasure to hang out with him.

"Elayne has gathered the majority into one military division," Perrin replied quietly.

"Farm boys with pitchforks and kitchen knives," Gallene said, moving to Perrin's other hand. He wore a highly polished breastplate and a three-plumed helmet. One of the man's eyes slid down the street. It could be very useful if controlled. "The first Trolloc will tear them to pieces."

"I think, Gallene," said Arganda, "you will soon discover how dangerous farmers can be. Especially when cornered.

- You both. Quiet! Perrin snapped.

"I didn't mean to offend anyone, Arganda," whispered Gallene. - This is not a question of class, but of training. Well-trained soldiers are equal to me in battle, both farmers and lords. But hastily assembled armies do not differ in skill. Queen Elaine shouldn't rely on them.

"I don't think she's going to," Perrin said. - But what would you do, Gallene? Sitting and hiding at home? This is the Last Battle. The shadow will throw on us all the forces. It is better that the common people are armed and ready, in case the soldiers fail.

The man hushed. Behind, the rest of Perrin's forces passed through the gate. Perrin himself was anxious to drown out the sound of boots and armor. If the Dark One discovers what they are about to do, the Trollocs will be waiting for them in the Ways. And yet to go without taking at least a small army with him was folly.

Difficult balance. Enough people to take care of the problems encountered, but few enough to incur those same problems. Perrin took fifty. Is this number correct? At night, he sat carefully reviewing his plan for the hundredth time, but the task still made him doubt the decisions he had made.

The paths are not a carefree walk through the forest. He suspected that he knew this better than anyone.

The last to pass through the Gate were six mules laden with supplies. In addition, each soldier carried with him an additional portion of water and food. Gallene doubted the need for so many provisions, but Perrin was firm. Yes, the path they had to take looked like it would only take a few days, but it wasn't worth the risk. And while he couldn't plan everything, he didn't want things to go down the drain over something as simple as lack of provisions.

However, he did not take any horses with him. Only pack animals. Bridges in Ways can be narrow, especially when broken or old. Better to rely on your own feet.

It suited the ail perfectly. Perrin brought ten with him, including Sulin and Ghaul. Ten Gaeldans, ten Mayennes, ten Whitecloaks, and ten people from Mesopotamia. That's all who made up his fifty soldiers. In addition, there were Grady, Neald, Saerin, Edarra, Seonid and her two Guardians.

Five guides. If the Light so desires, their services will not be required.

- Do you feel anything, Golden-eyed? - asked Seonid. The white-skinned and dark-haired Cyrian reminded him of Moiraine, although she was more severe. Curious... when they traveled together, he thought Moiraine was tough. Strangely, looking back now, he felt as if talking to him, Moiraine smelled of love. Perhaps he simply remembered the past as he wished. Like old Kenn Buie, who claimed that when he was young, pies were better at Bel Tyne.

In any case, Perrin believed the Seonid much more than the other Aes Sedai traveling south with him. At least she didn't go to meetings with Mashima behind his back.

Perrin looked out into the street, sniffing the scents in the air and listening for any strange sounds. Leaving two sentries at the exit to the street, he joined Seonid, who was following along the alley with two of her Guardians.

Their target was not a street, but a dead end, where the alley ran into the wall of what had once been the palace of Lord Bartanes Damodred, Friend of the Dark One and, coincidentally, Moiraine's cousin.

Now his palace has become Rand's school. Never before had Perrin been to this place, but the gate leading to the territory was found exactly where it was described. He knocked softly, and a stocky, grey-haired woman flung open the doors.

- Idrien Tarzin? Perrin asked.

The woman nodded. She smelled of anxiety. She ran the school and was told to expect their arrival. Perrin waited for all of his men to come inside, counting his men and women. Once again, just to be sure.

Finally, all were counted, and he closed the gate behind him, hurrying along the line of soldiers in order to be in front. Idrien hissed at them, ordering them to be quiet, then flung open the back door to the school.

Perrin stepped into the passageway, immersed in the strange smells of the place. Something caustic, incomprehensible, mixed with the smells of flowers. The outlandish aromas that Perrin associated with baked goods - soda and yeast - which, however, were not accompanied by the expected cozy smells, like the spirit of baking bread.

As the rest of the party entered the house, Perrin stepped forward, sniffing around the room, which reeked of the tannery. What is going on in this strange place, and why, from the very hall, did he smell old bones in this room?

He expected to find the scientists asleep, but as the steward led him down the corridor, Perrin came across several rooms with lights still on. In one of them sat a very tall man with long hair and fingers that ran over... well, some kind of device. There were wires and coils and things sticking out of the floor like metal wood. On the table in front of the scientist, fires burned in small glass spheres. Fixed points of light that did not flicker at all.

- Is he Asha'man? Galad asked, catching up with Perrin.

"I don't see the weaves," Grady whispered, joining them as Arganda led his squad through the chamber behind.

"Then... did he figure out how to use the One Power with coils and metal?" asked Galad, who smelled of anxiety. He seemed to find the idea very frightening.

Perrin shook his head and let the two of them go ahead, fearful of attracting the scholar's attention. The man didn't even look up, paying no attention to footsteps or silent conversations.

Perrin hurried, passing under a model hanging from the ceiling. She looked like a wooden person with wings tied to her arms, as if they were supposed to make him fly. The next room smelled of old dust. It was filled with bones that didn't look like any of the animals Perrin knew.

Eventually, Idrien Tarzin led them through a small door, perhaps reserved for servants, and they entered the gardens of the mansion. Perrin knew what to expect, for Loyal, at length, of course, had told him about his time here with Rand. The Way Gate stood within its own enclosure. On the ground next to him lay a guy with a bunch of star charts on his knees. His gaze was fixed on the sky, and what he expected to see beyond the haze of clouds lay beyond Perrin's understanding.

"I thought you were told to keep everyone away," Perrin said as he hurried over to the manager.

"Oh, don't mind Gavil," she replied. - He's not right in the head. He... well, we let him learn the Ways, as you can see...

Did you let anyone in? Perrin asked sharply.

"We are here to teach and learn," the manager said in a harsh voice. - He knew about the risks. And he... well, just stuck his head in there for a moment. This turned out to be enough. When we pulled him back, he only looked and muttered. Now he talks about the starless sky and draws star charts all day long. But it's all nonsense - he draws graphs of heaven that no one has ever seen - the woman looked at Perrin, and then - enveloped in the smell of shame - turned away. "We didn't open them again until Ogier came and punished us for what we had done. Of course, we could not open them ourselves - when he left, he took the key with him.

Perrin was silent. He led his squad inside the enclosure, where the Waygate stood, a stone portal covered in incredibly intricate patterns of vines and leaves. Perrin did not work much with stone, the closest thing to that was the bizarre attempts with silver casting, which Master Luhan laughed at. As if there was enough silver in Mesopotamia to spend on apprentice training.

And yet, the masterful carving of the Waygate has always fascinated Perrin. The creators made these stone doors almost alive.

"Thank you, Mistress Tarzin," Perrin said. "They will quietly lead me to Mesopotamia, and no one will know where we went.

Perrin glanced at Galad, who, bless the Light, said nothing. This man could be awfully honest at times, and didn't like the idea of lying about their mission. But Perrin was determined to do whatever it took to point the Shadow in the wrong direction. Even deliberately spread false rumors.

"You can go," he said to the manager. "But forbid anyone even to enter the garden, barricade the doors and don't worry about us. Remember what you were warned about before. The Shadow may well be planning to send troops through this passage. It may be quiet here in the city, but you are sitting on the front line.

The woman nodded. She should have smelled of anxiety, but nothing like that. Perhaps she just controlled her fear of this place very well. They had known for a long time that the Shadow was using the Waygate, and Rand had stationed guards there for most of the school's existence.

Unfortunately, a few guards won't be able to do much. Just close the doors. This Waygate needed guides who could travel while constantly watching over them.... Someone that Rand could send when he found extra strength.

Or... well, if he finds extra strength.

Mistress Tarzin stepped back into the doorway and closed the door behind her. Not that a deadbolt could do much against the Trollocs, especially when more significant measures proved useless. But Caemlyn's Waygate was firmly locked, like the one behind the stone wall that protected the entrance.

Pushing past his soldier, Perrin left only his escorts and guides at the Waygate. Then, stepping back, he nodded towards Grady.

"All right," he said. - Come on.

Saerin folded her arms across her chest, and Perrin braced himself for another argument. This part of the Aes Sedai's plan was not to their liking. In particular, Saerin didn't like her. The Stern Brown protested the destruction of such an ancient relic.

Luckily, when Grady stepped forward and looked focused, the woman didn't say anything. Apparently, Perrin's explanation suited her. This carved barrier meant nothing to the enemies in Caemlyn. It might not exist at all, considering everything that people did here.

Cairhien's only chance - like Caemlyn's - is for Perrin to find a way to block the Waygate from both sides.

"Well, my lord," Grady said. - Take care.

With these words, Asha'man blew open the carvings of the Gateway.

The explosion destroyed the cover, tearing it into several pieces. The pop came out muffled, as if coming from somewhere far away. Pieces of stone hung in the air, and instead of flying apart, showering the soldiers, they slowly floated down, falling onto the path in front of the Waygate.

Looking at the destruction, Perrin felt a pain that was only worse because he was the one who caused it. But the blacksmith's attachment to a piece of iron should not prevent him from melting the material if necessary. Now that the stone carvings were gone, Perrin took a breath and took one of the lanterns and held it up. Below, a glassy, mirror-like surface appeared. But the reflection was blurry.

Opposite Perrin, holding a lantern, stood a dark version of himself. Loyal said that once the Waygate shone like bright mirrors. This was at a time when they still had their own light.

Grady dusted his hands. The ancient doors looked peaceful. Perrin took a step forward, peering and listening. The last time Rand tried to use this Waygate, something terrible was waiting for him on the other side. Black wind.

However, today Perrin heard no cries of blood or death, nor did he feel any attempts to attack his mind. He saw nothing but the dark silhouette of himself. As he looked for signs of danger, his golden eyes seemed to glow, reflecting the glare of the lantern. Perrin didn't notice. It seems that this time, Machin Shin is not hiding inside, waiting for them.

He let out a breath as Seonid spoke thoughtfully to Grady behind him.

- Good job with the explosion, Asha'man. Did you somehow use Air to drown out the sound?

Grady nodded, wiping sweat from his forehead.

- Used to do so lately. An explosion might be useful, but I don't want to rip everyone's eardrums. And now, is it possible?

"Noise from the rails is what you should be more afraid of," Saerin said sharply. "We should hurry, just in case.

"Agreed," Perrin replied. He turned to the soldiers, who were looking at the whole performance with calm faces. Perrin assumed that many of them could guide no more than ordinary people. - Arganda and Gallene?

- Yes, Lord Golden-eyed? - Gallene responded, instead of a simple "Yes?", which was Arganda's answer. Both men smelled of impatience.

- You can come in. Together.

They didn't seem to like it. However, they still moved towards the glassy surface, as if approaching the dark versions of themselves living in the realm of shadows. After removing the stone carvings, the entrance was wide enough for two people. Arganda pulled himself up and tapped the surface. His finger seemed to touch the finger of reflection. The man winced visibly when, instead of hitting a hard surface, his finger got stuck in the archway. He glanced at Gallene, and the second man nodded, clutching his helmet under his arm.

Together, they stepped forward. Their faces touched the faces of their counterparts, and the men merged with the mirror surface, entering the Paths. After a moment, Arganda stepped back. The man's upper torso simply poked out of the opening, causing no ripples in his vitreous.

- On the other side is a small stone platform, as reported, Lord Golden-eyed. We haven't seen any sign of the Shadow or that...your wind.

"Good," Perrin told the others. - You can come in. One at a time, and slowly. I'll go last.

Galad approached him as the soldiers began to huddle together. He looked worriedly at the Waygate.

"I tried to convince the Children that we must walk the dark paths in order to follow the Light.

"Sometimes you have to take the dark path," Perrin said, "because there is simply no other. It doesn't mean you have to let the evil get in. Children could never understand this.

"I am no fool, Perrin," Galad replied. - I know the difference. But if we intend to resist the Shadow without accepting its ways, how can we justify using this... place?

"The paths are not evil," Perrin explained. "Shadow corrupted them, but that doesn't change the fact that they were built for good. The real evil is the Creatures of the Shadow who use them to attack us.

After a moment of thought, Galad nodded.

- I accept your arguments. You're good with logic, Perrin Aybara.

The Whitecloak stepped next and, never slowing down, not even emitting the smell of concern, passed through the Gate.

"A compliment from the Whitecloak," Seonid said to Perrin as she waited for her Guardians to pass. - What's it like?

"Strange," Perrin admitted. - Go. And remember, you can't direct inside.

"You keep saying that," Edarra said, stepping forward. The Loremaster had pale yellow hair, and although the woman appeared young, appearances were deceiving. Especially when the woman was worried. She examined her dark reflection critically. "Why bring five guides with you and then tell us not to use the One Power?"

"Don't swing your ax unnecessarily, Edarra," Perrin said. - The power inside will be corrupted, almost like the stain that was on Saidin. We'll probably still have to use it to make the plan work, but let's not do it recklessly.

Finally Edarra entered. And although the step of the Wisdom was not disturbing, and her head was bowed, she still smelled of nervousness.

Seonid smelled... a strange combination of emotions. Something happened between the two Aes Sedai and the Loremaster. Perrin didn't know what it was, but it looked like it was over. Oddly enough, Seonid treated the Aiel more respectfully than Egwene or other older Aes Sedai.

"Keep that Whitecloak on a short leash, Perrin Aybara," Seonid said as Edarra disappeared. "People like him change sides quickly when they see a mistake. I've seen this a dozen times.

She stepped into the Waygate, and the last of the Aiel followed her - only Gaul was left to wait with Perrin.

"We say in the Threefold Earth," Gaul remarked, "that the gango lizard will be happy to bite off your hand, and the asp will cut off your whole leg." I think some counselors could apply this to themselves.

"I trust them both," Perrin said. - Seonid can be rude, but she acts quite honestly. And Galad... Galad is simple. If he turns against me, I have no doubt that he will first fully explain his reasons. Better him than a dozen assistants who tell you what you want to hear and then pull schemes behind your back.

Gaul laughed.

- I will not call such an approach strange, Perrin Aybara. Not at all strange.

After Gaul stepped through the gate, Perrin moved forward, as if going into battle with his own reflection on the gleaming surface. He entered the Way only twice. First time - so long ago, with Moiraine. The second, when he returned with Loyal to Mesopotamia. It seemed to him that those events happened an eternity ago. In fact, some completely different person was looking at him from the Way Gate. A tough man with a weathered beard. Hard as the fur of a wolf whose instincts knew how to anticipate a particularly harsh winter. But Perrin could look at this man with his golden eyes and feel at peace with him.

Both the man and his reflection hung the hammer in a loop on their side. And both knew that this time they would not smell of fear, although they would still remain cautious. Stepping forward, Perrin touched the surface of the Gate, which washed

over him, cold as water. The moment stretched out—Perrin felt like he was walking through a thick piece of tar.

Finally, he slipped through and stepped firmly onto the other side, dissolving into the endless darkness.

Chapter 2

People opened the lanterns, putting up poles against the advancing darkness, but the light was not able to illuminate the space around. Perrin was ready to feel this oppressive darkness, but it still weighed on him.

The darkness here seemed thick, resisting the light. Surrounding him, blocking his path. With the exception of the Way Gate - on the other side of which, as if through dirty glass, a garden could be seen - everything here was featureless. Only the smooth stone lying under the feet, along which a faded white streak stretched from the Way Gate, and darkness.

This darkness. The soldiers, hardened in battle, huddled together. Perrin knew the feeling. There was always a wish that there was at least someone nearby. And though he knew it was only an illusion, it was hard for him to shake off the idea that the darkness was a fluid constantly flowing towards the light, flooding and slowly overwhelming it.

The air was odorless. Stale. Dead.

Several Whitecloaks stepped aside as if to look at the Waygate. Perrin ordered them back into line, then crossed a stone platform that was pitted and furrowed as if by the wind. But there was no natural wind here.

Each group of soldiers formed a small link - two rows of five people. Of course, the Aiel ignored the order as if it didn't apply to them. Perrin assumed it was. They wandered in pairs or threes, peering into the darkness as if looking for a place to strike. He didn't think he'd ever smelled a similar smell of unease from them. There was no fear, but there was no calmness in this place.

As Perrin was counting the links, he noticed Ghaul's absence. In the time it took Perrin to enter, the Aiel had disappeared into the darkness. However, before Perrin could ask about him, a single wiggle of light appeared in the darkness. Gaul raced back, carrying a lantern.

"The sign is clear, Perrin Aibara," he said. "I didn't see any trace of the Trollocs. No embers from fires, no discarded bones. They may be moving along the Paths, but they did not stop here.

"Good job," Perrin said, then asked quietly. - Do you show off in front of the Maidens?

Ghaul laughed so loudly that Perrin might have thought someone had poured brandy into the Aiel's ration. Gaul wiped the tears from his eyes.

"He asks if I'm showing off in front of the Maidens," said Sulin, an Aiel, as she passed by. She immediately burst into laughter. In such a dark place, it seemed strange.

"You are a good man, Perrin Aybarra," Gaul said, clapping him on the shoulder. "Behave frivolously in times like these. Showing off in front of the Virgins ... As if I had not yet been brought into such hot sands.

He chuckled again, though he smelled serious.

Aiel, thought Perrin. With a wave of his hand, he ordered the people to move. The residents of the Two Rivers led the pack animals, following the white strip lying on the ground. The Way Gate disappeared behind them, and for a while it seemed that the party was not moving. They seemed to be walking along an endless path in the inky darkness without any marks and landmarks, except for random holes under their feet.

At this point, their footsteps seemed muffled, and no voices could be heard. As if this advancing darkness choked all sounds.

Finally, in the light of the lanterns, a tall column appeared. The worked stone slab set on top of it seemed to come out of nowhere. Perrin stopped the people. Leaving them to watch the darkness, he approached the Signpost, accompanied only by the Aes Sedai, Asha'man, and Wise.

The stone was covered with fine writing inlaid with metal. The work was done so well that Perrin could not imagine how long it took to fill the entire slab. Judging by the graceful swirls and leaf patterns, it seemed that just one proposal from these Ogier patterns could take months.

However, they did not have to rely solely on writing. As they gathered around the pillar—perhaps standing closer to each other than usual—Saerin took out a small notebook.

'Alviarin's notes,' she said, lighting the book with her lantern, 'corroborated by more accurate indications we found on Murdraal's corpse.

She examined the slab, running her finger over the scroll fragments that had been reproduced in the notebook.

"Yes... I think that's enough to get us to Caemlyn."

How difficult can our path be? Nield asked. The darkness muted the young Murandi's usual impatience, but he smelled of determination. Once Perrin wanted to think of Nyalda as a boy - he was not yet eighteen winters old - but after everything they had been through together... well, there were few people in the world to whom Perrin would trust his back more willingly than Fager. Nialdu. "The darkness is capable of moving thousands upon thousands of Trollocs here. If they can find a way, then you, Saerin Sedai, can without a doubt.

"I doubt the Dark One sheds a tear when he loses a squad of Shadowspawn in this endless darkness," Saerin replied. However, I wouldn't risk it.

These writings are beyond my knowledge, and I would not dare to guide you myself. But as far as I can tell, the notes are accurate. On the third bridge on the right there should be a pillar with these marks here. If so, we are on the right track.

- Let's take a look at these ramps, - Seonid said in a businesslike manner as always,
- and check what we agreed on. The final decision to move forward must be made based on the results.

Perrin nodded, signaling to the soldiers to guard the rear and keep their ears open. Then a small group of guides, along with Gaul and Sulin, who slithered behind like shadows, headed to the right, to the place where the bridges emerged from the ground, curving into darkness.

Perrin hated the way these structures seemed to appear out of nowhere. From a distance, the light didn't illuminate them as one might expect. Instead, they simply popped out of the darkness when the light was brought close, as if reluctantly succumbing to its rays.

Despite this, here, on the edge, the Ways really became something inexplicable. The bridges branching off the main road stretched into the darkness, the roads into the vast nothingness. In addition, stone ramps ran up and down as they separated from the main path, leading, as Perrin knew, to stone platforms exactly like where they now stood. As far as he could tell, in addition to these platforms, there was another one directly above or below them. These structures seemed to have no visible support. One day, he tried to introduce them. The stone platforms were supposed to be discs - or perhaps Islands - hanging without any support and connected by a network of parapets and bridges.

In the end, he abandoned his idea, as he could not tell if his understanding was correct. The darkness that reigned in this place filled the eyes and thoughts, making it difficult to assess distances. Trying to imagine the Ways was like creating a blacksmith's puzzle with no solution.

The others were looking at the ramps and bridges, and Perrin could see some of them, including Niald, trying to make sense of them, maybe even sketch structures

in their heads. He noticed how, looking up and down, he shook his head and muttered Edarra under his breath. Well, he warned them.

"The direction post is exactly where it's marked on the notes," Saerin said, stepping towards him.

Nodding, Perrin waved at Grady.

- All right, Jur. Let's.

The others gathered around, and he smelled their alertness. Good. This means that he duly convinced them how dangerous what they were about to do.

Jur Grady, looking almost as time-beaten as these stones, assumed a focused air. He grabbed the Force.

"Create something small," Perrin said. - We need to know.

Extending his hand in front of him, Grady created a ball of yellow light, allowing it to float above his fingertips. He grimaced, reeking of anger.

- Blood and ashes! This is something I never wanted to feel again. As if spoilage and not cleaned. How can she still be here in this place?

"She's been preserved here," Saerin said. "Oddly enough, I feel it too, so it's not just the men. It looks like the decomposition of a piece torn from the body, which continues to rot, despite the fact that the corpse has already been burned.

"All right, Jur," Perrin said, pointing to the bridge they had no intention of using, "the one that had squinted to its side under the effects of an affliction that was gradually destroying the Ways. "Destroy a small part of that bridge.

Grady reached out and fired a small arrow of light and flame. Although Perrin couldn't see the weave, he could instinctively know that something was wrong with it.

Unlike any fire he had seen in his daily life, this flame had a sickly brown hue. Grady, who often showed stoic patience with the Force, smelled of nausea and unease.

Its fiery projectile knocked a piece of stone off the bridge, shattering the pieces into the void. Grady slowly released the Force and sighed. Everyone was quiet. Perrin tensed, listening for even a hint of wind in the darkness. He was ready to give up all efforts and would do so in the blink of an eye if he thought they could alert Machin Shin of their presence.

He didn't hear or smell anything.

Grady spat to the side, and Perrin didn't think he'd ever seen the man make such gestures before.

"Not exactly what the corruption was—but it's just another kind of disgusting thing. Then it seemed to me that I was breaking through the oil to touch the Force. Here is something...distorting my weaves when I use them. It was as if I had finished half the meal and only then found worms in the bread.

- How difficult was it to destroy this piece of stone? Perrin asked, pointing with his chin.

"It crumbled like powder, my lord," Grady said. - As if ... it was not a stone, but dry clay.

"That's how we can do it," Nield said.

The plan that, after much deliberation, Perrin came up with was simple. A small group of them will find their way to Caemlyn's Guiding Gate. Once there, they would destroy all the bridges and parapets leading to that particular Island in the dark, isolating it. These bridges were long. Destroying them could cut off Caemlyn, making it impossible for the enemy to resupply behind Rand's defense lines.

The chance to cut off the armies of the Shadowspawn was worth the risk in the Way. The execution of the plan, however, rested on two things - their ability to navigate and their ability to damage the stone paths that led to Caemlyn. They seemed to be convinced that they could do both.

"Then, we're moving forward," Perrin said. - Into the darkness.

Chapter 3

Perrin walked along a new graceful stone bridge, leaving into darkness. Hours passed, and yet it seemed as if they had made no progress. He remembered that feeling, the nagging anxiety that somehow the whole road was just an illusion. That he leaves one Island to go round and return to the same place.

Perrin felt a strange gratitude for the gouges in the stone. At least they were different on every bridge and Island. He just wished Grady's words wouldn't weigh on him. It crumbled like powder... As if he was a little nervous when, walking on a stone, he thought that there was no support under it.

Arganda walked alongside, periodically glancing over the edge of the bridge. Perrin resisted this desire. He did not need to look into this darkness, which resembled eternity itself.

In the end, people reached the end of the bridge and ended up on one of the stone platforms. The torches never managed to fully illuminate them. Perrin wished he could see the grounds in their entirety, instead of viewing the surroundings from within small, limited spheres of light.

Along the way, the soldiers huddled together, and Perrin stepped back to say a few encouraging words to them. It's hard to stay alert when you're crossing bridge after bridge with no sense of time or space.

Their detachment reached the new Pointer. This one is much worse. Hardly any letters could be made out. Saerin approached the stone, pulling out her notebook, then waved to one of the Maines to bring the lantern. Squinting, she ran her fingers over the stone.

"Such damage..." the Aes Sedai said softly. - All melted. Like a piece of sugar left in the rain...

- Can you find a way? Perrin asked.

After consulting the book, Saerin led them to the parapet that led down. Perrin quickly counted his men as they followed. Saerin was by her side, leafing through the pages of a notebook. He hadn't known the woman for long, but her straightforwardness set her apart from other Brown Aya sisters he knew. This pleased Perrin, and when the Aes Sedai volunteered for the task, he quickly agreed. "You're doing well," he told her when he finished counting the people. Together, they moved down the parapet—the last to go, except for the aiel, who had taken up position in the very rear. This part worried me.

"The instructions are clear," the Aes Sedai said. "The notes only contain directions for a few Waygates, but they are logical and understandable. I'm more worried about traps or misdirection.

Perrin nodded, though part of him was uneasy at the indifference with which it was said. If Loyal had one thing to explain to him, it was that the Way was not to be taken lightly. It seemed almost reckless to come here without Ogier leading the way. Loyal would be able to do more than just read the Pointers. His constant warnings—his boundless anxiety—would have made them more careful.

Perhaps Perrine should have taken on the role. He allowed the Aiel to roam ahead and behind, as was their custom. But Loyal never even allowed Lan to go scouting in the Ways.

"This place," Saerin said, "is different from what is described in the annals. The darkness here is not the darkness of the night, but something completely different. We have entered another place whose laws are different from our world.

- Have you studied the Ways? Perrin asked, cautiously seeking more information. During their meetings, when they were planning this trip, the woman hesitated, not daring to reveal everything she knew. But Perrin was used to seeing that from an Aes Sedai.

"I have devoted my life to seeking out the most useful knowledge," Saerin replied. And their practical application.

- Practical application?

"No one uses the Paths anymore," Saerin said, staring into the absolute darkness. "That makes them even more interesting, because there are obviously advantages here. The benefits that...before the re-opening of the Migration...were unique.

She smelled of curiosity, carefully controlled. And not too much - fear.

"You've been here before," Perrin said. - Is not it?

"Only a fool will enter the Way," she replied. - Everyone knows this.

The Aes Sedai's answer is beyond doubt. She probably didn't know how much truth Perrin could sniff out. However, for the time being, he left this topic.

Instead, he went to the Two Rivers and pack animals to tell them to be very quiet. He didn't want to spoil their mood, but... well, it's better to be gloomy than dead. Or something worse.

He moved along the column until he was in front, leading it. He was accustomed to seeing farther than other people, but he wasn't sure it was of any use here. It was difficult to say, because, in fact, it was impossible to see anything at all.

At least the aiel didn't go too far ahead. Five remained on guard directly ahead of the column. When Perrin was in the front ranks, Ghaul stepped back to join him.

"Looks worse than before," the Aiel said quietly. He lowered the veil, but seemed ready at any moment to raise it again. - If that's possible.

Gaul was right. When they reached the new Signpost, Saerin led them to one of the spiral parapets leading into the darkness. On the way down, Perrin had to go around gaps on one side of the road, then on the other. Holes were also visible in the center of the path, as if someone had lifted and carried away a stone from there.

Below he caught up with Galad. The tall Whitecloak looked up. He smelled strongly of disgust. Perrin knew the feeling, the strange sensation that the place they left must be somewhere directly above them, hanging without support from columns or other supports.

"This building must collapse," Galad said. "She belongs to the Shadow. The normal world doesn't behave like that.

"We are not in the ordinary world, Galad," Perrin said. - We...

He stopped. What is that quiet sound? Wind in the distance or just a rustle from the movement of one of the people? The hairs on his arms stood up, and he felt a chill run through his body. Perrin tensed, trying to hear through the muffled voices of the people and the soft thud of hooves on stone. The sound here seemed stifled.

Muted. And behind all this, he heard ...

Nothing. Nothing special. He was almost certain.

Galad bowed his head to Perrin. Most of the group settled on the Island, fetching rations for their midday meal—although, of course, they could only guess at real time, estimating meal times from the number of bridges and parapets they had crossed.

- Everything is fine? Galad asked.

"As far as possible in this place," Perrin said, though he caught Grady as he passed.

- Milord Golden-eyed? the man asked.

"Jur," Perrin said. "If we run into the wind, if it finds us, don't wait for my orders. Hit him with everything you can.

Grady looked at Perrin and then answered, quieter.

- Will it work? You know there's something wrong with the One Power. I... well, that thing you described. Will she react to force at all?

- Rand says he once threw back the Black Wind. He told me that he used the One Power to push Machin Shin back into the Gate when it seemed ready to reach out and grab him. If the Black Wind comes for us, it will be our only chance. Understand?

- Understand. We'll be ready. I'll let Nialda know.

Saluting, Grady left.

Galad watched the man leave. It smelled... nothing special, really. Perrin expected revulsion.

"No taunts, Galad?" Perrin asked. "No comments on the evil that the One Power represents?"

"I never thought of the One Power as evil," Galad replied. "It's just another tool that people use. However, any power and authority tend to degrade. Signs of her are all over the White Tower. Do not you agree?"

"Actually, I agree," Perrin replied.

"Asha'mans are frightening and disturbing," Galad continued. "But on reflection, I also consider them noble." To take what was given to them and try to use it to help rather than harm is commendable. More commendable than seeking taming. However, not many men are ready to take such a serious step, despite the fact that this is the right thing to do.

"Not now," Perrin said. – When the Source is cleansed.

– Not quite, judging by this place.

Light, thought Perrin. "I hope he doesn't mention this conversation in front of the other Whitecloaks. Some of them may take this as proof that the Asha'man are still not to be trusted. Few of them were as rational as Galad. Dane Bornhald, who passed by at the very end of the column, was an example. Being next to Perrin, the young man still smelled of hatred. And, oddly enough, guilt.

Perrin understood the hatred. Though Dane no longer believed that Perrin killed his father, that didn't change the old prejudices and animosities. But guilt? Is it because Bornhald was forced to kill his friend? Recently, the young man often smelled of brandy.

Perrin didn't let the soldiers rest for long. Moiraine always kept them moving, eating on the go. And in this Perrin was inclined to trust her wisdom.

Soon he ordered the people to advance, again ordering silence. Again, they immersed themselves in the atmosphere of this place. Walking through the too-silent darkness.

Stopping at each Signpost and then again at each bridge or parapet to check the signs.

When they got to the end of each path, the Aiel went ahead, looking for signs of the Trollocs. No one but the Aiel was eager to fulfill these duties, and Perrin did not let them stray too far. He remembered Loyal's careful warnings, imagining how easily even the most careful scout could get lost in the darkness. In this case, Perrin will be forced to leave him. Left to wander in darkness and loneliness until thirst or madness kills him.

By the end of the first day of their journey, they encountered exactly what Perrin had feared so much – a broken bridge.

He stepped towards the cliff, joining the Aiel scouts. The crumbling stone gave way here, and the ten-foot-long piece of masonry collapsed into darkness. Perrin knelt before the chasm, feeling the sharp edges of the broken stone. He could see the other side of the bridge, at the very edge of their lantern light. There it supposedly continued until it reached the new Island.

Below was only darkness. Will the fallen one fly until he dies of starvation, or will he hit one of the Islands first?

"I think I can jump over," said Aviellin, one of the maidens.

"The leap into truth is long," Sulin said. "Wetlanders can't do that, that's for sure. Don't be offended, Perrin Aibarra.

"I'm not going to," he replied, trembling at the very thought of trying. He turned, calling for Edarra and Saerin. They approached, defiantly ignoring each

other. Perhaps Saerin heard how Seonids were treated. Of course, Seonid was one of those who swore allegiance to Rand, so maybe...

Perrin hesitated. No flowers. Usually, when he thought of Rand, a whirlpool of color swirled before his mind's eye, showing Rand wherever he was. But not at this time. Were the Ways connected in some way with wolf dreams? He didn't see any pictures there either.

The group gathered a few steps from the collapsed part of the bridge.

"I've seen broken bridges before," Perrin said. - I expected that by following the planned path, we would avoid such problems. This tear must be quite fresh.

- What did you do last time? asked Seonid.

"Loyal led us down a different path," Perrin said.

Everyone looked at Saerin. Meeting Perrin's eyes, she showed typical Aes Sedai calm but shook her head.

One of the hallmarks of a strong woman is her willingness to accept the limits of her abilities. I don't think I can walk here on my own. If you insist, I can try, but I barely have the knowledge to determine our direction with these instructions.

Perrin considered this.

- Make us a bridge.

- Where can I get the stone?

"Not a stone," Perrin said. - Air. I know it's possible.

At the beginning, Saerin didn't answer.

- The hole is big, Golden-eyed. It may be too wide for me.

- Edarra can help.

- The question is not only in strength. The size of an Air Bridge has strict limits. This crossing over to the other side... well, it might be dangerous. Not only because in this place the One Power is tarnished. I will have to attach Air to the damaged stone on both sides. The bridge could collapse and take us all with it.

Perrin nodded, rubbing his beard again.

"First, see if you can create a bridge," he said. "If it works out, we will send people one at a time.

Others seemed to accept this decision as a reasonable one. Saerin spoke quietly to Seonid and Edarra, and then the three of them took on a concentrated look. Although this had been going on for some time, Perrin was sometimes surprised when people, including Wise Ones and Aes Sedai, did what he said.

"A bad experience," Saerin told him. "But I might find it useful. Is this really what men used to feel when directing the One Power?

"Worse," Grady replied from behind Perrin.

"The bridge is in place," the Aes Sedai said. We need someone to check how reliable he is.

Before any of the Aiel could volunteer, Perrin stepped into the abyss.

Several Wolf Guards gasped, but Perrin's foot landed on something hard. He couldn't see anything, but he felt as secure as if he were standing on a rock. Look ahead, he ordered himself and took the next step. Walking across the bridge, he kept his hand on his hammer - the internal warmth of the metal was soothing - and tried not to think about the endless nothingness under his feet. Sweat ran down both sides of his face.

Never before had he been so happy to touch the stone as he was when the last step was taken. Perrin took a deep breath and turned to see Gaul following. With the same look, a man could take a pleasant evening walk. He stopped and tapped his foot on the side of the invisible bridge, then leaned over the darkness. Mad Aiel, thought Perrin.

He flaunted, even if he didn't admit it.

The virgins followed, one at a time, and although several of them repeated the feat of Gaul, none fell. Perrin sent Gaul and Dev to inspect the next Island - warning

them to stick together - but he himself wanted to wait until all the people crossed over to the other side.

All this time he hardly breathed. He could have survived the death of people in the battle he commanded. It didn't please him, but he could handle it. But if if someone fell in there... well, it would haunt him for the rest of his life. He knew it like his own name.

In the end, only the guides and the Whitecloaks remained on the other side. Grady and Nyald moved one at a time, as calm as the Aiel, though Perrin could smell their nervousness. the Aiel were deprived of it as well.

Galad and his men remained.

Perrin could see how they hesitated before the abyss, though he couldn't smell it. Before, some of them had refused Aes Sedai Healing.

- Well? Perrin asked. "You asked to be taken to this place. Go now or stay in the dark.

Galad went first. Perrin nodded to him as soon as he was on the other side. This time, Galad smelled of anxiety.

What did you say there? Perrin asked. - A single force - just another tool?

"Perhaps the word 'just' was hasty," Galad replied, looking back at the bridge of Air as Bornhald began to cross it. - Tool, yes. But the same can be said about the fire, and I do not like to walk with such an abyss under my feet.

Perrin chuckled.

- Bye then...

Something crackled downstairs.

Perrin didn't hesitate. Stretching out his arms, he rushed towards Bornhald, who had almost reached his destination. Terrified, the young man stared down at his feet as the rock next to Perrin crashed, sending Bornhald into darkness.

Perrin grabbed the youth by the collar of his shirt, but the movement made him freeze, swaying precariously, halfway down the abyss. He snarled, clinging tighter to Bornhald, who was screaming with his arms outstretched. The youth caught Perrin's hand, throwing him off balance.

Perrin met Bornhald's gaze. And he didn't let go.

- Light! Galad exclaimed, grabbing Perrin and pulling him upright. Bornhald, swaying, hung over the abyss. The momentum of movement nearly pulled all three down, but after what seemed like an eternity, something grabbed them—something invisible—and pushed them back onto the stone bridge.

The three of them fell into a heap. Bornhald was choking and almost crying. Sitting down, Galad rubbed the hand he had struck in his fall. Perrin took a deep breath and sat up. He began to thank the Aes Sedai and the Wise Ones for the currents of Air that had saved them.

Then, he saw Niald standing at arm's length.

"Blood and bloody ashes, Lord Perrin!" - he said. - God forgive me! I almost missed you. I didn't hear anything until Bornhald screamed!

"It's all right, Fager," Perrin said, standing up and dusting himself off, "mostly because of the desire to move so as not to shake. "You saved our lives.

"You reacted quickly, Lord Ibarra," Galad said as Perrin helped him to his feet. - How did you do it?

"Heard the rock crack," Perrin replied. - That's all.

"I didn't hear anything," Galad shook his head. - This wolf hearing... Can another person learn it?

Perrin found himself standing, his mouth open.

- You? Do you want to learn THAT?

"Studying your talents will help me determine if they serve the Light," Galad replied perfectly rationally. "I realized that wolves do not serve the Dark One.

At least I have no evidence to the contrary. I - so far - do not see anything wrong with a person who learns what you do.

"I doubt the wolves will like you," Perrin said, and then found himself chuckling despite the darkness and the fall. He was cursed, he was hunted, he was feared because of his eyes. But no one ever asked if it was possible to become like him. Now someone has asked. And nothing less than the Whitecloak!

Galad squatted down next to Bornhald.

- Are you okay, Dane?

"I... Yes, Lord Captain. I think so... I think I'll be fine.

The young man reached for the flask in his belt. Galad let him take one sip, then carefully took the flask and tossed it over the edge of the bridge.

Dane watched it fly down. He smelled of horror. But Perrin shook his head in amused surprise. Galad has always been consistent.

Galad helped Bornhald to his feet.

- I'll watch him to the end of the bridge. Someone has to walk by. But first... He turned to the broken bridge, to where the Whitecloaks stood, the Aes Sedai and Edarra.

- Well? he shouted. - Can you make another one?

"We can," Edarra called back.

- Do it! he shouted, probably for the sake of his people. "It takes something more than the fear of death to frighten the Children of the Light. Even in this place we will walk in the Light, Aiel.

Nodding to Perrin, Galad moved forward, holding the lantern in one hand and resting the other on Bornhald's obviously trembling shoulder.

May we not run into the cliffs again, Light, Perrin thought as the rest of the Children of the Light crossed the new bridge one by one. He doubted that they could have persuaded Bornhald to cross another one.

Chapter 4

"It's okay to be afraid," Perrin said.

Bornhald raised his head. He sat on the edge of the halo of light.

Around them, the party set up camp to spend their first "night" in the Ways. The stone in this place didn't seem as shattered as the others, and Perrin tried to imagine the Paths as Loyal had described them, bright and sunlit. A place of life and warmth. As soon as he imagined it, darkness was right there. Invading, as she seemed to want to invade their camp, snooping around the line of light.

To contain it, people placed lanterns in a circle. Inside this ring, they laid out their beds and received from Arganda the schedule of shifts of the sentinels. It was remarkable that everyone seemed to be in a good mood, adjusting to the gloom of the place. While everyone was quiet at Perrin's orders, some of the Mayen and Gaeldan chuckled as they prepared for bed, exchanging friendly witticisms.

Perrin smiled, glad that at least the two groups got along. What was even more remarkable was that several Whitecloaks also joined them, laughing at some kind of joke. Is it possible that even these harsh people are able to find a common language with others?

Bornhald, however, was not among them. The young Tarabon sat alone. His thinness seemed natural, but during his stay in Perrin's camp, the young man had almost turned into a skeleton.

"I'm not afraid," Bornhald blurted out, biting off a piece of bread.

Perrin sat down, deserving a closer look.

"Listen," Perrin said quietly. "We have our differences, but you are now under my command. The last battle is on the way. There is simply no more time for resentment.

Bornhald continued to eat.

- Is it because of your father? Perrin asked. - Jeffram...

"Don't," Bornhald stopped him. Taking a deep breath, the young man continued. - Don't say his name. Just... don't. I beg. He has nothing to do with it.

- Then - Bayar?

"I don't need your help, Perrin Ibarra," Bornhald replied. And your sympathy. I'll look after myself. Leave me.

- Good.

Sighing, Perrin rose to his feet. He made his way back to the center of the circle of light, where Galad was looking over his camping men, hands clasped behind his back.

"Something is troubling Bornhald," said Perrin. The nearness of the fall shocked him.

"Dyne... has been increasingly unstable lately," Galad replied. "Tell me,

Aibarra. Does the name Ordet mean anything to you?

Perrin exhaled sharply.

- Yes.

- Dane keeps muttering it.

"Ordeth is the Friend of the Dark One," Perrin said. No, even worse. He is the man who brought the Trollocs into the Mesopotamia. He pretended to join the Children, but in reality he was just playing with them, using them for his own purposes. I'm not quite sure which ones. Probably wanted to get Rand's attention.

"I must point out," Galad began, "that you have been accused of the same thing—delivering Trollocs to Mesopotamia. But you insisted there wasn't enough evidence to warrant a verdict. Can you somehow prove that one of the Children was guilty of this crime?

"He is not one of the Children, Galad," Perrin said, looking back at Bornhald. "As for the evidence, once we get out of here, I can bring a lot of eyewitnesses to the crimes this man committed. And now... Light, did Fein... Ordet... do something to Bornhald? It didn't look like the young man had worn the same curse that Mat had worn when the dagger was still his.

"I'll ask," Galad said. "And I will talk about this Ordet with the other Children, to see if any of them have met him."

Perrin nodded, accepting a piece of jerky and some cheese from Tam. He brought them when he saw that Perrin hadn't eaten anything. From time to time, the Two Rivers men took care of him, like women. However, when he went to the Aiel, he was glad to eat. He only noticed that Gaul and Aviellin had returned. The group set up camp at the Signpost, and Perrin reluctantly agreed to let the two of them cross the bridge to scout the situation.

"More signs of Trolloc presence on the next island, Perrin Ibarra," said Gaul. - A pile of bones. Several red drawings on the ground. Maybe blood. They are at least a few days old.

Light. What were the Shadow Spawn doing? Did you drag people with you to eat along the way?

Is that why they are so focused on capturing Kandor? Perrin thought. "To take captives and let them eat?"

This thought made me sick.

- We listened to the darkness, - said Gaul, - but did not hear any sounds in the distance. However, who knows? Trollocs can be very quiet when on a short leash - plus, this place seems to distort the sound in ways I can't imagine.

"They didn't destroy the Pointer, as you feared," Aviellin said. "It's perfectly clean, and there are no troll marks around.

Perrin nodded. He believed that with the notes, the murdraal could destroy the Signposts. This would not greatly affect their task, but it would be a loss for the

future. Anyone else who wished to follow this path would be deprived of such an opportunity.

But... will there be others? thought Perrin. It was obvious that cleaning the Source had no effect on the corruption in the Paths. Little hints from Ogier indicated that they were about to leave, leaving the humans to fight on their own when the time of the end came. Even Loyal, one of the bravest of his kind, was terribly frightened by this place and did not know how to restore it.

Perhaps Perrin should do the world a favor by destroying not only Caemlyn's Gate, but everything he could find, leaving that ravenous darkness to feast on his own corpse.

Once upon a time, there was vegetation on the Islands. Loyal's voice sounded in his head, flying back from memories of another visit to the Ways. Here was the grass, green and soft, like a feather bed. Fruit trees to add to the food you brought with you, apple, pear or quince... The fruits were fresh and juicy no matter what time of year it was outside...

He would like to see all this. It seemed like some incredible crime to leave such a beautiful place with no hope of healing. Although the powers that be and the elite now had access to Travel over any distance, the high demands placed on this method meant that such a path would never be available to a simple traveler. Perrin thought of the Ways, flourishing and welcoming, enabling people all over the world to travel easily and safely. And when the darkness tried to invade this picture, he forced it to retreat.

Now he needs to focus on his task. One that, unfortunately, was more about destroying the Ways than restoring them.

How often these days his hammer had to fall to break rather than build. Perrin shook his head as he chewed on his jerky and wondered if he should order a reduction in sleep from six to four hours. They had seen more and more signs of Trollocs in the last few hours, and Perrin wanted to get out of here as soon as possible.

But if they did have to go into battle with the Shadowspawn, he wanted the people to be rested and ready to fight. He would prefer to use guides only as a last resort. In the end, Perrin reduced the halt to a compromise of five hours. Having given his orders, he found himself seated on the edge of the ring of torches, from where he could watch the camp being set up, listening to brief reports from the leaders of the individual groups. It was wonderful that after one day of hiking there were already things that required his attention. One of the pack animals has lost a horseshoe, a soldier has rubbed his foot with new boots... because of this, they may risk breaking their oath to refuse the healing of the Aes Sedai. And the alarming report that one of the waterskins had leaked and was half empty before anyone noticed.

Perrin dealt with each minor problem in turn, and then, just in case, he listened to the reports of the Aiel he had sent to scout the nearby bridges.

Loyal would never let people walk away from a group like that, but Perrin wasn't Loyal. He thought he could judge what risks his soldiers were and were not capable of taking.

Of course, he didn't lose a single pair of Aiel in the darkness. Each of them returned. Listening to their reports - nothing out of the ordinary - he noticed that Edarra had stopped paying attention. They didn't run to her before bringing it to his attention.

The camp fell asleep. In this dark place, the soldiers seemed to fall asleep faster than ever before. Perrin watched as the two Aielks on duty—Aviellin and Sulin—joined the other lookouts who were sitting by the small fire. The girls sat down, and Sulin spoke animatedly.

Two from each group, Perrin noted. The White Cloaks sit next to the Two Rivers, Mayen, and Gaeldans, who drink from the same waterskin. And even the Aiel tell stories to others. Perrin didn't catch everything that Sulin told them, but it was just

a normal Aiel story because the people looked puzzled when they listened to it. Yet they smiled and asked the woman to tell more.

"I don't think I understood what you were doing before, Perrin Aybarra," Edarra said. No, not before this trip.

He stared at her, completely forgetting that she was still sitting beside one of the lanterns.

"I thought that once everything was done, we would return to the Triple Earth," she continued. "Let's continue to live far from the wetlanders and their soft ways.

And yet, a few months of traveling with you... got me thinking. You're creating something grand that shouldn't surprise me. The touch of a blacksmith. You use it as quietly and accurately as a spear searching for a gai'shan.

He didn't know how to understand her words.

"Wrestling brings people together," he muttered as he finished chewing his meat. "I didn't do anything special, Edarra. Except just keeping some spiky fools out of each other's throats long enough for them to figure out who their real enemy is.

"You create," she said again. "And, oddly enough, I would like to follow wherever your shadow falls. Once upon a time I would have said that you should abandon these wetlanders and go into the darkness only with us. Who else do you need? Noisy wetlanders only slow us down.

But now I see what you're doing. And I think that I would be wrong to make such an offer. You have wisdom, Perrin Aibarra. And it is not just words.

Perrin looked back at the small fire. He ordered more wood to be taken, knowing that the people would be grateful for it when they had to spend the night in the Ways. Something special was happening between the people - the Whitecloaks, the Mayennes and the Gaeldans were talking and listening to the stories of the Aiel.

Perhaps he shouldn't have worried about this before the Last Battle. And yet something whispered to him that if life after the Battle continued, and he was going to do everything for it, Light help him, it would be important that each of these people felt that they had taken part in this.

Edarra stared into the darkness.

"There's something here," she said thoughtfully. "It reminds me of the world of dreams.

Are you a Dreamwalker? Perrin asked in surprise.

"No," Edarra said. "I always hoped to be her. As the youngest of the girls, I... But no. You shouldn't talk about it. I have no personal experience, but this place reminds me of what others have said about going to Tel'aran'rhyod. A black void that stretches forever. A place where nothing seems to be the way it should be.

"There is a resemblance," Perrin said, causing her to look at him with her head tilted. "But the Dream World isn't that bleak. It's not a place of endless darkness, but a place of endless possibilities." Perrin chewed on the cheese given to him. He didn't want cheese, and he didn't want jerky either. Something about this place always spoiled his appetite. "I won't be able to go there while we're here, and I regret it. I need to get back. Get in there with all your might. Physically.

Edarra's gaze was sharp.

"Don't think about it, Perrin Aibarra. This evil.

Perrin didn't answer. He just chatted. Perhaps it shouldn't even be mentioned.

But a new problem that hung over him demanded his attention after the task was completed. The strength in wolf dreams—in Tel'aran'rhyod—was in delicate balance. The more you fell into sleep - the stronger your presence was - the stronger you became. However, you always risked falling too deep and dying in the real world.

The Destroyer was strong, so strong. Perrin needed an opportunity, a way to defeat him. He put his hand on the hammer, feeling the warmth inside the weapon.

It won't end until you become prey yourself, Slayer, he thought. - The killer of wolves. I'm done with you.

"In many ways," Edarra muttered, looking at him, "you're still a stupid child, despite all the ji you've earned."

Much is worth her recognition of his wisdom. Well, Perrin was already accustomed to - though he didn't approve - of being treated like that by women who were a year or two older than him.

"You cannot enter the Dream World in the flesh, Perrin Aibarra. None of the Dreamwalkers will teach you. This evil.

- Can you explain why? Perrin asked.

"To enter the Dream World in the flesh means to lose a part of yourself," Edarra replied. "I know only this, and it would be wise to recognize this wisdom, Perrin Ibarra.

Perrin nodded, though she said nothing more than what he'd heard before. What does that mean? What is the real risk?

Servants of the Shadow are at risk, Perrin thought. What risks must we take to stop them? He was ready to come here, risk being lost in eternal darkness, or be driven mad by the Black Wind. That move alone might have been said to have gone too far, but Perrin suspected it was just one of many.

Chapter 5

Looking around lazily in the darkness, the two Trollocs sniffed the air. One had a wolf face and ears that made Perrin's hair stand on end. The creature's legs were bent like the paws of a wolf, but the arms were definitely those of a human. The bear-like second Trolloc had an almost human face, with human teeth and human eyebrows, but its arms were covered in fur.

People who heard descriptions of Trollocs often imagined that the creatures looked like humans with animal heads. But such descriptions did not adequately reflect the frightening mixture that the creatures were. There were human features in each of them - especially in the eyes - but they were crudely mixed with something clearly inhuman. No, the creatures did not look like an animal cut into pieces, mixed with human parts. Rather, they were a horribly perverted hybrid of both. A horror that had too much of an animal to tame and too much of a human to trust.

Worst of all, the Trollocs smelled wrong. Musk, but with a taste of rotting meat. Perhaps this is due to pieces of food stuck in their fur or under their nails. No proper animal will ever be so dirty.

The Trollocs stood at the very center of the bridge that led from one Isle to the next, holding their lanterns to spread light. The creatures wielded a suspicious amount of light—not just two lanterns on poles, but three more at their feet. Perrin had never thought that the Trollocs needed light in the outside world, but the darkness in the Ways was absolute. Therefore, he believed that there was nothing strange in the few lanterns brought. But so much?

Perhaps they simply experienced a natural fear of this darkness. However, the beasts didn't seem overly concerned, as they spoke to each other in gruff voices, using a language Perrin didn't know and didn't want to learn.

Ghaul nudged him, and together they silently slid down the stone bridge. Of course, they did not take the light with them. The Trollocs' senses were as good as Perrin's - they would see the light or smell the burning.

This meant that Perrin and Ghaul were forced to return to those waiting for them in complete darkness. Crossing this bridge, knowing that if you stumbled, and he would fall into the abyss, it made Perrin tremble, as if a spider was crawling somewhere along his spine. He took a deep breath as he caught the glimpse of a covered lantern ahead. Four more Aiel squatted beside him. Sulin was among them.

Here Perrin and Gaul left their shoes to walk forward silently. Notably, the Aiel did not dissuade Perrin when he wanted to go explore the light source with them. He began to think that they respected his abilities as a lumberjack.

"Those Trollocs are sure to guard the way," Perrin said softly, taking a seat by the lantern.

"We can get rid of them," Sulin said quietly.

Perrin shook his head.

- This couple has a lot of light. And they act loud. Something is wrong here. As if they were bait.

The small group was silent.

- If I thought that I would be chased, - Gaul said slowly, - soldiers who know how to be quiet and dangerous, I would have assessed the situation. I would deploy two guards that I know will be noticed, and then watch who comes out of the darkness to confront them.

"Sometimes they do that," Sulin agreed. - Two rows of sentinels, the outer one should constantly report that everything is fine.

Gaul nodded.

- Okay. Just in case, I'll go around these two and see if there are others.

- Will you get around? Sulin asked. "Stone Dog, this is a ruined bridge, two paces wide. How are you going to get around them?"

Ghaul smiled and then slipped back into the darkness. Perrin looked at Sulin, who completely closed her lantern. All together, they followed Gaul.

They crawled forward, feeling the edge of the bridge under their feet.

Ghaul was sitting in the same place they had watched from only a few minutes earlier. Perrin could barely see the man in the faint light of the Trolloc

lanterns. When Perrin and the four Maidens caught up with him, Ghaul glanced at them and then walked across the bridge.

Perrin held his breath. What is Gaul doing?

On the spot. Ghaul tumbled over the edge, clinging to the bridge with only his fingertips. He crawled to the side, moving one arm, then the other. Silently, without even scratching a stone with a fingernail. Light, it hung from the bridge, dangling over this endless blackness. Perrin could only imagine what it must be like.

The Trollocs did not seem to notice him. One of them sat down and began to gnaw something, and the other yawned, sticking out his wolf tongue. As Ghaul approached the Trollocs, Perrin held his breath, his fingers gripping the hammer handle tightly. It seemed to him that the Aiel would fall into the abyss at any moment. Just looking at it made my hands ache with fatigue.

Don't let go, thought Perrin. "Don't you dare let go, Gaul."

Ghaul's fingers slid within inches of the creatures, but they didn't notice. However, when the Trolloc Bear's jaws suddenly broke a bone, Perrin jumped slightly in surprise.

Ashamed, Perrin looked over to where Sulin sat beside him. He smelled the scent of embarrassment coming from her and realized that she, too, jumped at the sound.

Well, part of him was glad to see signs of her tension. Ghaul acted as if such dangers were common among the Aiel. The fact that Sulin behaved differently spoke of something else.

Perrin and the four Maidens waited for Ghaul's fingers to disappear into the darkness behind the Trollocs. Then - a little more. Perrin thought that if the Aiel fell, he would probably keep a warrior's silence so as not to betray everyone. He won't scream. Just perish.

The seconds stretched into minutes. Perrin grew more and more worried. What if Gaul is in trouble? What if he stumbled upon a Shadowspawn in the darkness? What if he was there, in that blackness, bleeding, dying?

Just as Perrin's patience nearly ran out, as he himself was about to attack the Trollocs, something flew out of the darkness. A spear rushing like a charging raven. It went straight into the Trolloc wolf's throat. The creature gurgled in pain and staggered back, eyes wide. The bear turned around, and Gaul jumped out of the darkness, holding a knife in his hand.

The Trolloc opened its mouth, but Gaul struck, clinging to the ten-foot-tall beast and driving a knife into its eye before the creature could scream. They fell to the ground, and Gaul yanked the blade out to plunge it into the other eye.

Perrin rushed forward, but managed to take only two steps before Gaul got to his feet. After a moment's hesitation, the Aiel yanked the spear from the dead wolf.

- I made my way to the next Island, - said Gaul, waving his hand. Found two others. They didn't have much light. As you may have guessed, Perrin Aibarra, they were watching. I quietly killed them and then searched the Island. There were no others nearby, but I dared not go too far.

Smiling, Perrin squeezed Gaul's shoulder. Aside, the Maidens raised their spears over their heads. Gaul blushed. Perrin couldn't remember seeing this before.

The squad searched the dirty carcasses but found nothing useful, so they simply pushed the bodies over the edge of the bridge. Perrin wished there was a way to hide the blood.

Maybe they can wash it off? If someone starts looking for these four, it will be better for them if he does not find any signs. The vanished Trollocs could have escaped or been caught by Machin Shin.

He'll deal with it as soon as they regroup. Perrin led the Aiel back over the bridge and then over the parapet to where they had left the rest of the troops, who had huddled behind the lanterns. Arganda was relieved when Perrin emerged from the darkness.

- Milord Golden-eyed? whispered the Gaeldan, raising the lantern. - What happened? "We killed the sentries," Perrin said.

"Very well," said Gallene. So it's a battle! They wouldn't have posted sentries if there wasn't someone they could report to. I'll bet we'll find at least a couple of Trolloc fists nearby.

Perrin looked at Sulin, who nodded. She is agree.

"Then we must find them," Perrin said. - For now, let's go. Slowly, carefully and with a large number of scouts on patrol. Tell the people about what we found, Gallene. And warn them to be careful. We are already close.

Chapter 6

Perrin felt as if the darkness was watching him, sizing him up. The unnatural silence of this place reminded him of a forest that had suddenly fallen silent - frozen in that moment of tense expectation that comes just before the attack of a predator.

In near-perfect silence, they crossed the next bridge, whispering orders. Even the pack animals seemed to feel something. Along with his officers and advisers, Perrin walked to the next Signpost. Here he waved his hand, and the aiel broke into pairs to see if an ambush awaited them.

They carried covered lanterns with them, and only faint glimmers of light separated them from the darkness.

"Bless their Light," whispered Gallene. - And return it safe. In dozens of battles, I have stood face to face with death and never blinked. But something in this darkness seems to defy even the bravest of my people.

"It's worth considering what kind of people just go into it like that," said Arganda. He and Gallene often went together. At first, Perrin thought the rivalry made the two look out for each other. Now he wasn't sure.

"I heard some whispering in the dark," Gallene said. "They were betting on who would get lost and not come back. They seemed to take it as a game."

Arganda nodded as if he expected this.

"An amazingly tender moment," Gallene continued.

- Gentle? Putting each other to death?

"I saw how many laughed instead of crying in the morning before the battle,"

Gallene said and looked into the darkness. "They behave differently, Arganda, but they remind me of that. About people joking while preparing for battle. They get nervous. They don't like this place either, but they're doing their duty. I have often heard of the deadly Aiel fighting under the banner of Lord Aybarra. But I don't know if I've ever seen them as... human-like as they were at that moment.

Perrin nodded in agreement, though he was inwardly surprised. He was accustomed to seeing open hostility from the leader of the Winged Guard rather than reflection.

The scouts have returned with word of a new group of Trolloc lookouts. the Aiel successfully got rid of them, but the news made Perrin even more worried.

They still hadn't had to face the main body of the enemy, but each group of lookouts brought the inevitable closer. Someone will be looking for these dead Trollocs, and the Fade has many more soldiers. They can easily be trapped between two enemy armies with no chance of escape. Unless you risk leaving the intended path.

The group moved on, passing the place where the Trollocs died. Perrin didn't need to see the blood to recognize him. He smelled the stench in the air.

At the next Signpost, Saerin checked their location and found the bridge they needed to cross. There are two Islands left before Caemlin. Perrin expected it, counted on it, but it was so hard to believe that they were successful. Each bridge was similar to the others, differing only in cracks in the crumbling stone.

The scouts stepped forward again. Darkness consumed them. Gaul and Sulin soon returned.

"Perrin Aybarra," Sulin said. - There's a hole in the next bridge, but it's been patched up.

- Made it?

- Tree, - said Gaul. - Let's go and have a look.

After waiting for other scouts, they moved forward. When Perrin got to the right bridge, he critically inspected the damaged part. The patch looked strong enough, but was created very roughly. There were chips sticking out of the sides, and many of the nails weren't hammered in all the way. The patch was covered in symbols and words written in blood.

- Is she trustworthy? Galad asked.

- We passed through it, - Gaul answered. - Sturdy enough.

Perrin nodded.

"Besides, she supposedly survived the Trolloc crossing, so we have nothing to worry about. However, let's go in groups of three or four.

When it was Bornhald's turn, Perrin was flustered, but the man simply wrapped his cloak tighter and stepped forward. Lost in his own thoughts, Perrin followed him. At the center of the bridge, the Whitecloak stopped and turned, staring into the darkness.

- Did you hear that, Aibarra? - he asked.

- What? Perrin asked, feeling a shiver run through his body.

- Screams.

Perrin turned to the next in line, a bearded Whitecloak named Golever. The man shook his head, indicating that he had not heard anything.

Perrin tensed, listening, trying to catch even the faintest hint of the rushing wind. It was the sound he feared the most. The sound that made him spend most of their last short rest, just as he thought he almost caught it.

He knew it was just nerves because nothing could be heard. Except... what is it? Not the wind. Not something that chills the soul. But... it was... it was like light...

What is stupidity? Man cannot hear the light. All is quiet, Perrin was sure of it.

"There is nothing, Bornhald," he said.

- Not. I hear a scream, Bornhald's red eyes glaze over. - Poor soul. It looks like he's falling into darkness. Falling forever. Screaming so no one can hear...

"Bornhald," said Perrin. - You didn't fall. You are safe.

"You should have let me fall, Aybarra," Bornhald snapped. Turning around, he continued on his way.

They reached the foot of the bridge, where Sulin and Gaul were waiting for them.

"The pointer is in place," Sulin whispered. - But he's not needed. And the book that the Aes Sedai carries.

- What? Perrin asked.

Sulin waved her hand.

- Come closer. You can't see from there, although some might. This place...

Despite her words, Perrin squinted into the darkness - and was startled when he spotted something. A glimmer of light. He was so accustomed to this place absorbing light and sound that what he saw almost made him nervous.

How big does the light source need to be if I can see it from here? he thought.

After instructing Gallene to look after the detachment, he told everyone to wait. Then, gritting his teeth, he followed Gaul and Sulin into the darkness. It was a fire, in fact, not one fire that burned in the distance on the next Island. As they approached the Signpost, they could see it better.

All together, they knelt down near the stone slab, not daring to come out from behind it, so as not to step over the edge of the Island, falling into darkness.

"How the shadows around the fires move," Sulin whispered. - Figures.

"Trollocs," said Perrin. He could smell their strong scent. "They guard the Way Gate. Perrin and the Aiel made their way back to the waiting party, where Perrin had gathered the leaders. Crowding around Sulin's small book, they confirmed the information as much as possible. There was only one bridge left to the Waygate. It was there that the fires were burning and the enemy was waiting.

- And now what? Arganda asked, squinting into the darkness, though Perrin doubted the man could see the light in the distance. - We could just blow up the bridge between them and us. Will it help?

"No," Saerin said. "I can't navigate here myself, but from what I've seen, there are several roads to each Waygate. If we break one bridge, we will delay the Shadow, but only slightly.

"We can't let them continue to get supplies and reinforcements behind our lines," Gallene said. "We need to capture this Island and hold it long enough for the guides to do their job.

"Sounds like we're going to be stuck here," Tam said, "even if it works."

"No," Perrin said. - Not perfect, but the task doesn't seem suicidal. If we can take out this group of Shadowspawn, it's easy. We destroy the bridges, then head back the same way. If we succeed in pushing them back, we will first destroy the bridge between us and them, and then we will cautiously retreat, bringing down every bridge we crossed.

He hated the thought of hurting the Ways even more, but that was what they had come to do. And the longer he was here, the more he became convinced of the correctness of such a decision. It is better to cut off a gangrenous hand than to let it kill the body.

"The battle plan is rational," Gallene said. - If we assume that we are able to hold the bridge that we cross, then we are able to continue the offensive.

"I guess it depends on the number of enemies," Arganda remarked. - I'm still worried that we might get surrounded.

"Our last escape route is the Waygate itself," Perrin said. "We can enter them if we have to.

- To the captured city, - said Arganda.

"It will only take us a little while after we leave the Way Gate to open the Gate to escape," Seonid said. "I hate to experience it, but I agree with Lord Ibarra. This may be the last option.

"Numbers," insisted Arganda. - We need to know what we're up against before making plans.

Perrin nodded. He went away to confer with the Aiel. Apparently it was now the turn of Aviellin and Feralin. The women went into the darkness to do the most dangerous job of getting close enough to the fires and counting the enemy.

Perrin ordered his soldiers to line up and organize the defense of one of the bridges. Just in case. Each clang of armor made Perrin flinch, but he endured, his heart beating wildly, waiting for the return of the Maidens. They came out of the darkness, completely without light, and accepted the raised spears of the sisters without comment.

"We got close enough to watch them by the fires," Aviellin whispered. - One hundred and twenty Trollocs. I'm sure of it, unless there's more in the dark. Two Night Riders.

Feralyn nodded in agreement with the number.

Over a hundred trolks and two murdraals. Enormous strength for his fifty soldiers, although they had guides with them.

How good are their fortifications?

"They didn't pass through the Waygate," Aviellin said. "I think they are the lookouts left to watch this place. We expected this. Their cauldrons are full. There are people in the paddocks, Perrin Aibarra. Wetlanders in once beautiful clothes.

"Prisoners from Caemlyn," Perrin said, feeling sick. - To eat.

He had two sketches from the Aiel showing the location of the fires, the paddocks, and the Waygate itself. He showed them to his officers and advisers, deliberately cautious. Something about this place made him want to fight, to start resisting - the sooner this happened, the sooner he could emerge from the darkness.

Does it seem to him that the light of their lanterns is now dimmer than it was the day before?

He forced himself to hold the wolf back while the squad assessed the situation.

- Lord Golden-eyed, - said Gallene, - I propose to attack quickly and decisively. If the guides sneak up and strike a crushing blow with the One Power, it will sow chaos and confusion in the ranks of the Trollocs. Then the soldiers can easily take control of the battlefield, sweeping away enemies.

- Arganda? Perrin asked.

"It's a good strategy," the short man agreed. - In another situation, I would agree with her without hesitation. But this will require a lot of energy from the guides and cause a lot of noise. You have warned us against both.

Perrin scratched his beard as he studied the map.

"We can't do everything silently," Tam said. "You can't just make the Trollocs disappear. If you don't want to rely on guides, we can try

force the enemy to attack us at the bridge, and then pierce him with arrows. We will draw them into a long battle and retreat.

This plan worried Perrin even more. He thought about the possibility of leading a squad through the Ways, the possibility of successfully using an attrition strategy against an enemy who could constantly replenish his forces using the Ways.

"No," he said. "We must strike and latch on—hit hard, sweep them away and prevent reinforcements from passing through the Waygate. This is the only reasonable plan.

He raised his head, and the soldiers nodded in turn, all including Galad. They saw it too.

"We need to be quieter," Perrin said. "That means as little direction as possible, but I think we can use Gallene's plan." We'll send out guides with the Aiel and force them to attack the enemy with barrage fire to weaken and confuse their ranks. Then the rest move forward. Let's go carefully. Mind you, I don't want people to accidentally throw each other off a bridge.

Perrin waved Grady and Nyalda over to the map.

"I want your first strike to split the Trolloc forces in half. We'll pour in through the gap you're creating, trying to push them over the edge." He pointed to Edarra, Seonid, and Saerin. - Your first task is to kill the Vanishers. I don't want to lose a dozen people to these creatures. When the Vanishers are defeated - guide only a little. Clear?

Seonid nodded immediately and Edarra said "Okay". Both answers seemed to surprise Saerin. Perhaps she wasn't used to women who could readily submit to... well, anyone.

The Devs and Gaul nodded as well when he explained their part to them - sneak up with the guides. He then gave orders to the soldiers of Arganda. Gallene and Galad will follow behind. The Dvurechens should remain on the bridge in the very last ranks, and then try to take a position on the flanks. The battle would probably be too fierce for the archers, but he would like to have them in reserve and - if things went badly - cover the retreat.

Perrin got up with Gallene's men. As much as he would not like to go with the Aiel, he understood that he would only get in the way under his feet. Ghaul and the rest of the Aiel slipped into the darkness again, leading the five guides and the Seonid Guardian. Perrin counted the seconds. People moved around nervously. He nervously unsheathed the Mah'alley'nir.

The warmth of the hammer under his fingers was soothing. Some of the Winged Guardians moved, one of them accidentally thumping his sword hilt against the iron breastplate.

"Calm down," Perrin said in the all-too-empty darkness. - Wait for the sign.

He forced himself to stand still instead of pacing back and forth in front of the troops. They stood in three rows, right at the head of the bridge, close enough for Perrin to see the shadows moving around the fires on the Island.

It's time for the Last Hunt. Before that there were only skirmishes, but now a real war broke out. He knew he was ready. What does this say about him? For many years he tried to return home to live peacefully in Mesopotamia. Now he wanted to fight.

Carefully, deliberately, he released the wolf. He didn't start this war. He didn't raise the hammer to strike first. But he could finish it - with all the cruelty that she demanded.

A flash of light lit up the air above the Island.

- Forward! roared Perrin, rushing across the narrow bridge, hammer raised above his head.

Chapter 7

Perrin got to the Waygate faster than any of his men.

Trolloc bodies covered the island, smoke billowing from the charred corpses. As he ordered, the guides hit the center. Perrin joined the Aiel, and together they undertook to weaken the main enemy forces. They acted as a wedge whose purpose was to split the solid stone in two, driving the Trollocs left and right and leaving the center - where the captives and the Waygate were - clear.

The people who joined him were strangely quiet - Gaeldans, Mayens and Whitecloaks alike avoided the battle cries. No trumpet was destined to announce the beginning of this battle, and Perrin warned the people to fight in silence. Of course, one cannot expect absolute silence from the battle, and the battle gave rise to a

feeling of silent despair. The men wheezed and muttered. The Trollocs growled. Weapons thudded and clanged, but even those sounds were muffled - all-consuming darkness.

Ways seemed penetrating, thirsty, drinking sound and light.

Perrin gritted his teeth as Ghaul, beside him, lunged at a Trolloc with the beak of some bird of prey. He swung the Mah'allainir, each blow causing the Trollocs' skin to hiss and smoke.

Perrin was a wolf, and the wolf lived in him. There was a time when he could control it, allowing the person to control it.

But now is not the time.

He was close to the captives, hurling aside the ram-like Trolloc just as a dying Vanisher writhed and writhed nearby.

The air was filled with flashes of fire. They scorched the Trollocs with waves of heat. Perrin held his ground as the Trollocs tried to drive him back. The plan was dangerous, because if the enemy came to his senses, Perrin's men could be driven to the center and surrounded.

Perrin continued to fight, feeling the beat of the hammer as if he were pounding on an anvil. They made a good team with Gaul. Perrin's heavy blows caught the attention of the Trollocs, and as long as they focused on him, Ghaul was able to slide, spearing opponents who were out of Perrin's reach or who were trying to flank him.

In battle, time meant nothing. As he slew his enemies, there was only Mah'allainir's swipe, the Trolloc's howl, and his heavy breathing. The battle looked terrible. Enormous figures of Trollocs, lit by fires, fought the men who held back their screams, even as they fell bloodied to the stone floor.

In combat with the Trollocs, it was hard not to feel small. The weight of the hammer could not be counted on to force the Trolloc back. Perrin struggled with the creature pierced by four arrows fired from a Two River bow, and even Perrin's hammer slamming into its skull did not cause the Trolloc to fall.

Gaul's blow finally finished off the enemy.

As soon as one terrible creature collapsed, the second, emerging from the darkness, took its place. For a moment it looked like they were being crushed into a heap, forcing them too close together to fight.

But Perrin asked every captain to bring their best soldiers, and the men did not flinch. Whether they wore a polished breastplate, a feathered helmet, or snow-white robes, they fought shoulder to shoulder. Following his instructions, the guides made small targeted strikes, burning the Trollocs here and there to break down any resistance they might mount.

Finally, bit by bit, Perrin's forces began to push the Trollocs back. They stretched their formation, allowing the Aes Sedai to come forward to help the wounded. Perrin left the fight, heading for the wooden pens that held the captives. He struck the first castle with Mah'allainir.

- If someone knows how to use a sword - take it from the wounded. Otherwise, stay close to the center of the squad and don't get in the way.

The eyes of the people inside were empty. While in captivity, they saw terrible things. On their way to freedom, they huddled at the door with their heads down.

- Do not go into the darkness! Perrin warned them as he broke the next cage. "Stay with us, or you'll be here forever."

Perrin didn't have time to check if they obeyed. He charged back into the line, where the Trollocs began to give way - they fell back, stumbling over fallen bodies as his men pushed them further and further. Nearby, the Maidens threw back a snarling group of six creatures that lost their balance and fell into the abyss.

- Perrin! someone shouted. A loud voice seemed to pierce the darkness.

Perrin turned around, trying to get his bearings. He was going to join the Whitecloaks and Gallene's people. The fires near the open cages and Waygate were still burning.

The gates were open. On the other side, Perrin could see figures moving as if in slow motion. They were gathering around, preparing to enter. It was Grady calling him, pointing at them.

"Get ready," Perrin said, running up. "We must not let them get reinforcements from the other side. They can only enter two at a time. Must be..."

Perrin paused, noticing something strange about the way the figures moved. That graceful gait, the way they crouched straight into the Waygate, without hesitation or worry. It all reminded him... Aiel. The people who entered the Ways carried kadin'sor and spears, though their veils were red. Shocked, Perrin lowered his hammer. They're not Aiel, are they? The first pair, thrusting their spears forward, charged straight for the Aes Sedai. Light! They must be Shaido who have passed into the Fade.

- Destroy them! Perrin Grady said. - Right now!

Grady nodded, and his face took on a concentrated expression.

- Light! Perrin, they can guide!

They are damn strong! stammered Nield. - They cut my weaves as soon as I create them.

Another pair of red veils followed, and after that another. Grady created a fire projectile, but one of the enemy Aiel blocked it, creating a bright flash of light. The enemy was doing something Perrin didn't quite understand.

- Is it really an aiel? Saerin demanded, jumping up to them. She, Seonid, and Edarra, along with their Guardians, did what Perrin told them to do—watch the wounded, gather captives, and send them out to help the soldiers only when absolutely necessary.

As Perrin began to explain, one of the red veils raised a hand above its head, releasing a beam of pure white light. It didn't appear to be aiming at anything in particular, but the beam was so bright that Perrin had to close his eyes.

What was it?

The rest of the red aiel also raised their hands, weaving streams of light into the blackness of the ceiling. The Trollocs howled. Their screams rang through the air as the last of them disappeared over the edge of the Island. But something about those beams—the dazzling beams so deliberately created—took Perrin.

- Stop these men! he shouted to Grady and Nyalda. - Use everything you have!

The two Asha'man were clearly trying. The explosion lifted one of the red veils into the air. The others turned and took off running - diving right into the Waygate. Grady and Nield dealt with the second, but the other four slipped back into the outside world.

Everyone was quiet. Perrin's soldiers congratulated each other on their brief but frantic battle. They suffered minimal losses, captured the Island and rescued the captives.

At first glance, the attack was successful. It even seemed that the strange aiel guides - who had only appeared briefly - had only arrived to realize they were outnumbered and to get the hell out of there.

Perrin saw things in a different light. As Saerin fussed about trying to convince the Whitecloak to accept the Healing, he tried to listen. Perrin looked at the Travel Guides.

Gates and strange Aiels, whom he could see on the other side. They moved slowly, due to the incomprehensible difference in time between the Ways and the outside world.

They lowered their veils and smiled. Satisfied with themselves.

The doors of the Waygate began to close, blocking red veils from Perrin's view. And as soon as his people, preoccupied with their wounds, calm down, he heard a soft, distant sound.

Weak howl, like a breath of wind. Somehow, the enemy learned to call on the Black Wind.

Chapter 8

- Fast! Perrin said, grabbing Niald by the shoulder and then looking at Grady. "We must exit through this Way Gate.

The shutters closed more and more, cutting them off from the light. Jumping over the corpse of the Trolloc, Perrin rushed to the exit, to the rescue. If the Black Wind is moving towards them, they should leave now.

- Lord Golden-Eyed! Grady called out, rushing after him. - Perrin, listen! We won't be able to get through. Light! Can you imagine how we will try to get out if these guides guard the entrance? We can only go two by two. They will kill us as soon as we appear outside.

Perrin pulled up at the Gate. Sensing his unease, the two-rivers who had been guarding the guides while the infantry fought huddled around him. Tam slid the arrow back on the string, staring into the darkness. Nearby, the Aiel stepped over the fallen Trollocs, finding those that were still alive and finishing them off.

- Perrin, boy? Tam asked. - Something is wrong?

"We're trapped," Perrin whispered as the Waygate closed. Grady was right. Trying to break through them is suicide, if the enemy expected this.

But stay here?

Perrin tensed, listening for the slightest sound. He couldn't hear anything, but that faint whine he'd seen earlier echoed in his head. In addition, he felt... felt as if there was some kind of smell in the air. The smell of decay.

"Get everyone back," Perrin said. - Fast! Quiet! Gather the wounded, take those we rescued, and retreat the way we came. We need to get off this Island.

"But..." Niald said. - We have captured the Way Gate. We need to destroy the bridges, cutting off the Island. This is our job, right?

"These Aiel summoned the Black Wind somehow," Perrin said, pointing with his hand. - We need to get away from the place where they released the light into the air. Now, go.

No one further argued. Passing information in low voices, the soldiers withdrew from their combat positions and began to retreat cautiously. On Perrin's orders, they threw away some of the supplies and tied those who were most severely wounded to the pack animals. Tam, along with the rest of the Two Rivers, took care of the former captives.

They had to sharply push people to force the captives to move away from the fires. Perrin took the wounded Whitecloak under one arm and Galad under the other, and together they crossed the bridge. Perrin didn't know if Whitecloak had refused Healing, or if his wounds were simply not too severe to be a priority.

They left twelve dead. Small losses on the one hand, although the loss of each was terrible. It seemed monstrously unfair to leave these brave men alone in the dark.

- What did you say there? Saerin asked, trotting along as they crossed the bridge. "Do you think those red-veiled Friends of the Dark One can summon the Black Wind?" Do you think he serves them?

"I doubt Machin Shin serves anyone but his own hunger," Perrin said. - And I hope I'm wrong - I hope he's not following us. But this signal must have a purpose. The aiel didn't attack us. They just created light and left.

Saerin chuckled, looking over her shoulder as the fires began to fade. It was as if the lack of attention and the darkness were choking them.

"I wonder how the Shadow moves so many Trollocs through this place," Perrin grumbled, still supporting Gower with one hand. 'When I have walked the Ways before, Saerin, both times the Black Wind eventually found us. He senses the noise, the Force, the life, and devours Trollocs with as much gusto as humans. I saw it myself. But the enemy is moving hundreds of thousands of soldiers.

"What if they found a way to distract the Black Wind?" Take him away? The Shadow can enter the Gate in the distance and draw Machin Shin's attention, holding him while the others move through the darkness.

"Guessing," Saerin said. - Knowing the consequences, you can not adjust the reasons for them.

Finally, they were on the other side of the bridge. Perrin turned and listened. A distant, quiet sound reached him. Wind sound. Elsewhere it would be normal. Here it was the scariest thing Perrin could hear.

"We need another Waygate," he told Saerin. - Where are the closest? I don't care where they lead, as long as they lead us out of the Ways.

"Are you sure you really want this," she asked. "I said that I doubt my ability to navigate here on my own.

"Either you find a way out," he said, "or this place will devour us all." There is simply no time for hesitation.

"I am not a frightened child who trembles at the coming test, Perrin Ibarra," she said. "I'm just being honest, but I won't hesitate." The woman opened the note book and flipped through it. - If I lead us into darkness, we will never return.

- Anyway, do it.

She nodded briefly.

- Give me a minute.

Perrin used the time to calm people down. Ironically, he found one standing apart from the others. Bornhald was on the edge of the world. Standing on the bridge, he looked to where they had come from.

- What is it? he asked Perrin. - I hear something. Light wind. It will be good to feel the wind. Everything here is motionless, like death itself...

"Blood and ashes," Niald said, raising his hand to his head.

Perrin got everyone moving as Saerin moved forward, leading them over a bridge—one they hadn't crossed before. Perrin hurried to help the injured man again. Nearby, Seonid tried to apply Healing on the run to an injured Mayenne who was placed on a pack mule. Perrin could no longer sense any emotion from the human.

"This is the place," said Seonid. - Because of the damage, healing here is uncomfortable. I'm afraid I'll leave wounds infected instead of healed.

"No more Power," Perrin said. - Healing, too, - he looked at the Mayen, who was leading a mule carrying his unconscious friend.

- I'm sorry.

Perrin joined Saerin as she read her notebook.

"I don't know if it will work," she whispered to him. "The notes say there's a Waygate across the four bridges this way, but it doesn't say where it leads.

Four more bridges? It will take time. When they started moving over the new bridge, people muttered. Perrin realized that their ears were only now picking up what he had noticed before. That howling wind grew louder.

Four more bridges. Perrin made a decision. He stopped people, calming them down. Then, he ordered them to huddle together, be quiet, and fully close the shutters on the lanterns.

The order caused fear to show on their faces. Arganda looked at Perrin as if the Wind had already caught up with him and he was mad.

"This is our best bet," Perrin told them. "We must hope that he will reach the Waygate where the fires have been lit, but he will not smell us here.

- And if he smells?

"I hope not," Perrin said, fear growing inside him. - Now, do as I say.

The people obeyed, bless their Light. One by one, they closed the lanterns, forcing everything into darkness.

The blackness has become absolute. No one spoke, no one even whispered. Though Perrin could still smell them. Panic, fear of the darkness of this place.

He could smell sweat and anxiety.

Now they all heard the sound of the wind, the hurricane, the howl that came from the place they had just left. Perrin twirled the hammer in his hands, knowing full well that it would be useless if Machin Shin caught up with them. He forced himself to stop.

The sound of the wind increased, becoming a terrible rumble in the distance. Then, Perrin began to parse the words.

... blood, so wet, so fluid, so bleeding, drink it, drink it, drink it...

Light. Perrin held his breath.

... how sweet, sweet to kill and tear and drink and drink and drink. Drink, drink it and kill it. Be mine, be mine. Tear, torment while he screams, break bones, take them for yourself. Kill, maim, crunch and sing... Aibarra!

The wind turned towards them, growing louder. At that moment, Perrin realized that no amount of hiding would work. The wind picked up their scent. He knew they were here.

- Open the world! he roared, jumping to his feet. - And run!

Chapter 9

People were waiting. They opened the blocked lanterns and rushed to run across the bridge.

They understood everything.

Perrin urged them on, telling them to run faster. There was no more time for whispering and hide-and-seek. He grabbed Azi, the two riversman, helping the man to walk.

Perrin was almost carrying the lame man, but Azi wasn't the only one left behind. Galad fiddled with Golever, and the Aes Sedai were behind, along with the rest of the Two Rivers, who were trying to help their former captives, many of whom were weakened from the apparent lack of food.

The distant howl of the wind grew stronger.

Light, thought Perrin. "Even if we all ride horses, we still won't be able to overtake him. No choice.

When the party reached the next Island, Perrin handed Azi over to the Seonid Guardian. Turning back, he waved his arms vigorously.

- Don't stand still! he shouted.

The urgency in Perrin's voice must have alarmed people. The cry made the crowd of captives stir, and they poured from the bridge to the Island. Galad and Golever hurried after them. Only a lone figure in white froze behind, staring into the darkness.

- What is it? asked Bornhald.

"Our end if you don't keep moving," Perrin called to him.

- He's coming after me, isn't he? Bornhald said. - Light, it knows my name. How does it know my name?

"Come on, idiot," Perrin ordered, tugging on Whitecloak's shoulder. This brought Bornhald out of his stupor, and he began to run. However, as Saerin led them over the next bridge, he kept looking back, while most people preferred to look ahead or down at their feet.

They didn't want to know, and Perrin didn't blame them. The sound was rapidly approaching, and what had once been a quiet breeze now became like an eerie howl of voices interrupting each other. It drowned out Perrin's screams.

...death, so appetizing, so sweet to the taste, suck out your leaking life. Blood, blood, blood and pain. Pain, pain, pain and death. Death, death, death and loss...

Like a thousand singing voices. The Black Wind was a product of the Ways, an ancient product, the essence of madness itself.

"How can it know..." shouted Bornhald, his voice almost drowned out by the howl of the Black Wind. - There was so much blood. A human couldn't do something like that, right? Even Ordeth? It is not right. They weren't Friends of the Dark

One. Some were just kids...

People got to the next Island. The wind tugged at Perrin's cloak and then... and then he felt it. A terrible hurricane swooped in from all directions. Saerin, leading the way, froze in place, and Perrin's party halted. They huddled together in the faint light of the lanterns, their clothes fluttering and flapping in the wind.

"He's here," said Bornhald, stopping at the edge of the Island.

- Grady! Nield! called Perrin, turning and pointing the Mah'allainir into the darkness.

... Aybarra, Aybarra, Aybarra. He promised to drink, he promised to kill, so sweet, sweet to sing, sing to us. Tiny souls are so delightful to eat, eat and sing. Sing, sing, sing!

The two Asha'man unleashed streams of sickly yellow flames. Chunks of black ash flowed into them like flakes of dirty snow.

The Force pushed back the usual darkness of the Paths, but not what was chasing them. Darkness incarnate, a whirling wind, flowing and spinning on its axis, rolling in wave after wave.

His voice... his voices... were thunderous. Even struck by fire, he screamed with pleasure. Shed blood, crush bones, grind, have a feast!

People behind Perrin fell to their knees. Screaming, Saerin, who stood in front, created her own painful beam of flame, which was joined by the beams of Seonid and Edarra, spreading in all directions. The wind hit them, and the quivering mass of it bulged and vibrated. Flashes of light shot through her like frozen sparks. For a moment, Perrin actually thought they were winning.

Then the blackness around began to rapidly thicken, becoming stronger. By the light of the lanterns, by the sound of the Black Wind's song, by the screams of the people, by the feel of the hurricane hitting his face and cooling his skin, Perrin saw, breathed, and heard. Machin Shin turned out to be much bigger than he thought. Perrin focused on the clump in front of them, the clump they were fighting. He felt something else, a deep, far-reaching darkness.

This blackness not only reached the size of an army, it could even swallow up most cities. While part of the creature writhed under the blows of the guides, the rest of its body bypassed them, braiding the Island with itself.

They are surrounded. The bridges leading to the exit were caught in Machin Shin's insane whirlwind. The wind turned into a whirlpool, mocking the men and women who watched in horror as the fire of guides became smaller and smaller, more painful and more painful.

Grady and Niald, both trembling and white-faced, paused for a moment. Then something new shot from their fingers - beams of white-hot light, one in both directions.

These rays left their afterimages in Perrin's eyes. So bright they were hard to look at - in fact, being close to them made Perrin feel like he was about to burst into flames. Deadly fire, forbidden weaving.

It threw off parts of the wind, causing Machin Shin to bubble up like skin thrown into a fire. And yet his song did not stop, the insane chorus did not stop.

... pain, so sweet, so sweet to sing a song, so wonderful to break and kill...

For some reason, Machin Shin only seemed to get hungrier by being restrained. Perrin put his hammer on his shoulder and turned around. His heart was pounding.

Exit. There must be a way out.

Gaul was close by.

"Then we'll wake up," he said softly. "I would like to know if this Last Battle will be won. Perhaps if I have a dream again, I will know it.

"So much blood," muttered Bornhald. "Aybarra, I'm sorry for...for what we did..."

The scent of his emotions startled Perrin, despite the terrible wind.

Pain, fear, loss, rage.

- I feel sorry for your family. It's all Ordet. I should have... I...

Bornhald gave Perrin a seemingly blank look, then jumped into blackness.

- Bornhald! roared Perrin, lunging forward as the wind whipped up like a rearing predator and engulfed Whitecloak.

... souls, so sweet! So sweetly gnash and feel the end! Feel, and tear, and devour, and drink blood! Shed and drink blood!

Howling, Machin Shin wrapped around them tighter like a snake. His voices echoed like a mad choir, each member shouting their own song, trying to drown out the neighbors. Perrin stepped back, raising a hand against the rising wind. Gaul reluctantly joined him, the rest huddled together in the very center of the Island.

The guides continued to release fire and light. But they seemed to be trying to fight the air itself. Machin Shin didn't have a body that could be destroyed.

Perrin's back bumped into Galad. People huddled together, and a crazy whirlwind circled around them. Lowering his hammer, Perrin thought of Faile. Randa and the Last Hunt, in which Perrin is not destined to run. May the Light help lest its failure doom them all to defeat.

He looked at Gaul, who nodded in response. Last push. Into the darkness

Perrin could no longer hear the screams of men and women. Only the roar of the wind and the singing of its voices. New voices came and went, breaking any coherence, if there ever was one at all.

... sweet! Sweet to sing! Say it...

... let the blood spill, take the blood! Blood!

...raise axes...

...drink bone marrow, suck, vomit, spill, grind....

... Aibarra, Aibarra, Aibarra promised! Break Aybarra...

...keep in line...

... take and drink, give ...

Perrin froze.

Raise axes?

- Gaul, no! he shouted, grabbing the man to keep him from jumping into the darkness. Perrin tensed, listening, trying to separate the madness of the wind from what he thought he had just heard.

Low sound, rumbling bass, harmonious and contrasting so strongly with the insane disharmony of the wind. Perrin grasped at the thread of sound that ran through the darkness. A humming, rumbling song that somehow overwhelms Machin Shin's frantic voices despite the volume of their cacophony. She destroyed them. Like a stream of water from a broken barrel, spreading across a flaming wooden floor. He heard it. He could almost hear!

Raise the axes, hold the line

Where the walls will fall

You stand there bravely

Raising an ax, you accept this fight.

Will break the plow
A lot of roots
Let the branches bend
from our blows.

Raise the axes, hold the line
Where the walls will fall
You stand there bravely
Raising an ax, you accept this fight.

Machin Shin winced. Perrin peered into the blackness that lay on the other side of the Isle. Yes, light was moving along one of the bridges. The light and the steady rumble of boots, growing louder. Creatures with thick, strong legs and arms the size of tree trunks. Their ears were flattened and their faces were menacing. Ogier - men and women, with axes on their shoulders, sang a beautiful, quiveringly harmonious song in deep basses.

She flooded everything around, and Perrin's people began to pick up. The Ogiers entered the Isle, and their song became ten times louder, and the people turned towards them, like plants seeking sunlight.

Let the night come
And the fire devours the wood
We sing a song about power
And we praise the smoke above the earth.

Raise the axes, hold the line
Where the walls will fall
You stand there bravely
Raising an ax, you accept this fight.

Machin Shin trembled and howled as if the words hurt him. Perrin felt the power of Ogier's song. The lanterns carried by his men seemed to shine brighter.

- Do you feel it, Jur? Nield asked.

- I think I can touch him! Grady called back. - It's so clean...

The men stopped guiding and Perrin, who held out a hand to shield himself from the wind, turned to see the two Asha'man raise their hands and create two beams of bright flame that were clearly purer than the ones they'd created before. A bright light, not a deadly fire, but a weaving that breaks the darkness. The beams shone as light should have. A light that dispels shadows and casts back darkness instead of being consumed by them.

The Black Wind howled, screaming in hatred, and its singing began to disintegrate. The words have become fragments. Saerin walked over to the Asha'man and attached her light to theirs. It reminded Perrin of something very warm and familiar. Sun. Strange that after only a couple of days here, he already thought of sunlight as something half-forgotten.

The wind howled again. His cries were distorted by light and song. Then he began to retreat. They did not destroy him, but he could no longer resist in this place, where they merged with each other, supporting each other, the rays of light and the song. Seonid and Edarra joined the others, and all five guides began their advance as the Ogiers stepped off the bridge onto the Isle. The two groups united, and Ogier, still carrying axes on their shoulders, continued to sing.

Finally, as the madness in response to the even passionate song reached its climax, Machin Shin yelped with a thousand voices and then rushed into the darkness. He

disappeared in a few moments. The cloaks and clothes of the soldiers hung motionless, and the Ways fell back into their eerie silence.

Perrin had never been so happy to hear nothing.

The Ogier lowered their axes.

- Oh, Perrin! the voice exclaimed. Loyal jumped out of line and rushed forward, twitching his eyebrows. "Did you see that, Perrin?" Our song drove away the Black Wind! I didn't know it was possible, and I don't think I should tell you how scared I was. Everything I studied told me how stupid and hasty our decision was, but I insisted that we should do it. Can you believe it? When we heard a sound in the distance, I spoke to Elder Haman. You know he's back. Right here. I told him that Machin Shin could react to our song if there were enough of us. You know, Ogier created this place with the old Aes Sedai. Growth songs were sung here, and I thought that perhaps the songs would be created again...

Loyal fell silent as Perrin pulled him into an embrace.

Loyal, how are you? How did you get here?

"Oh, it's not that interesting, Perrin," Loyal said, laughing.

When Perrin released him, Ogier reached into his pocket and pulled out a small piece of paper, holding it carefully in his hands. The words were written by a human hand. *Loial, son of Arent, son of Halan, who reads this. I chose another for this task, but sometimes it can be unreliable. I'm instructing you to help him with this matter. The gate to Caemlyn must be securely sealed, as that is where the Shadow plans to strike. In the past, you have seen fit to comply with my requests. If you've ever listened to me before, do it now. This is vital.*

Signed - Verin.

"I showed this to Elder Haman," Loyal said, "and he agreed that we should at least check the Gate if we were going to the Last Stand. Ouch! You missed this part. I spoke and thought that they were going to open the Book of Transitions and leave. But they listened to me! And everyone agreed that we should fight. Our axes are now with long shafts, and no excuses. I spoke to them, Perrin, and they listened to me. Even my mom, Perrine. She's here. Do you see her over there? You know, she never seemed pleased with me, but she went with us to fight.

- Oh, but you have to be brief. If there is ever a time to be brief, it is right now. Brief, yes. Well, we came to see and heard the wind. We saw those lights in the dark and knew we had to try the song. Otherwise, he would have devoured us. It was our only choice. Do you know where the rest are going? We must join the Last Stand. We're going to go to the Waygate in Shinar. These are the ones we opened before, right, Perrin? You remember, don't you?

"I remember," Perrin said. He laughed. "Yes, I remember," he nodded to Elder Haman and Loyal's mother, who approached him. - Greetings, elders. Your arrival was quite timely.

Elder Haman's ears twitched. His white beard hung down to his chest, below the mustache that flaunted on either side of his face.

- Thank the young man. His impatience led us. Everything is very hasty.

Ogier seemed a little stunned. Loyal's mother rested her ax on her shoulder and looked around sternly. Knowing the Ogiers, they probably argued for weeks before entering the Ways and still considered the decision too hasty.

"Ta'veren," Loial said quietly.

- Who? You? Perrin asked, turning to him.

- No, no, of course not. You are Perrin! We needed you. Perhaps that is why I was able to convince the others to participate in the Last Stand. At least you brought us here. I am sure about that.

Perrin shook his head.

- This time, my friend, I disagree with you. This is not related to me. It's all courage. Yours, Loyal. And yours, Elder Haman, and yours, Kovril, daughter of Ella, daughter of Sung. Thank you. From the bottom of my heart, thank you.

To his surprise, Kovril smiled.

- There were those among us who would have preferred to leave you and the whole world to live for the Shadow .. I'm not one of them, human. Trees are not destined to grow if the Dark One takes this land.

Loyal looked surprised.

- But...

"In order to find truth in a dispute, my son, there must be an opponent in it," she explained. "Those who argue, through adversity, actually know the true depth of their adherence to their own convictions. Don't you know that the strongest roots are those trees that grow under the gusts of wind? She shook her head reproachfully, though with visible tenderness. "But that doesn't mean you should have left standing, as you did, on your own. Luckily, this has now been taken care of.

- Did you take care? Perrin asked.

Loyal blushed.

- Well, you see, I'm married now. Erin, you know? She's right here. Have you heard how she sings? Isn't her song beautiful? She walked with me in the front rows. Being married isn't so bad, Perrin. Why didn't you tell me it wasn't so bad? I think I even like...

Perrin laughed, patting his friend on the shoulder.

- I'm sure it suits you. But let's go. If you want to join me, then I have business.

Chapter 10 Rest in the Light

The Ogiers sang a low, rumbling song. It vibrated inside Perrin, forcing warmth into the very depths of his soul.

To the sound of the song, the guides illuminated the air. Their efforts were not enough to see everything, since the Paths were huge. But now Perrin could finally see the place. The Way Gate stood on huge stone platforms that looked like hilltops and connected to floating islands of stone that looked like small disks. Bridges and ramps sprouted from them like vines.

In the light, everything around looked organic. The paths seemed like a completely different place. Walking through them in the darkness, Perrin thought they were much wider and more sinuous than the elegant structures that now appeared. For a moment, he could imagine the Ways as they once were - green and light, grown, not built.

Maybe they can find a way to restore everything. For now, however, their job was like that of a farmer tending his field, uprooting stumps to let new life grow. With the hesitant blessing of the Ogiers, Grady and Nyald destroyed all the bridges and parapets leading to the "hilltop" on which the Gate to Caemlyn stood.

There were almost a dozen of them. Shards of stone fell, plunging into endless darkness, which, despite the light created by the guides, still seemed endless.

Pieces of the last bridge have sunk into darkness. Raising the lantern high above his head, Perrin listened, but could not hear the sound of the impact.

"This is the day of mourning," said Elder Haman, standing beside him. On his shoulder lay an ax with a long shaft. - The day on which we were destined to witness the death of something grandiose, destroyed by our own hands in the name of creation. I am almost inclined to think that the price paid is too high.

"The Waygate itself remains," Perrin said. - We may have gone a step further than you when we closed them - but it's not forever. Bridges can be repaired, Elder Haman.

Ogier chuckled.

"It was necessary, Elder," Loyal said. "Verin Sedai asked us to do this, and no one should refuse an Aes Sedai." This is the way of wisdom.

With a deep, rumbling sigh, Elder Haman shook his head.

"Well, it's good to have you here, Wolf Brother," he told Perrin. "We couldn't close this hole on our own. Our axes cannot bring down bridges like the One Power did, and we could never hold the Way Gate against troll attacks. And yet, I'm sad to see it. Yes, it's sad..."

Elder Haman joined most of the Ogiers as they continued to sing their humming song. Perrin, Loyal, and Erith followed him. Behind them, a group of guides trudged wearily - the destruction of the bridges required enormous forces, especially given the battle that preceded this. However, tired or not, they continued to create luminous spheres, illuminating everything around. As the ogir sang, that light flooded the Paths as it should, though ordinary lanterns still seemed fragile and weak against the darkness.

Erit continued to glance at Perrin with her saucer-sized eyes. She seemed to find his own eyes mesmerizing, and Perrin bore it without complaint.

- So it's true? Loyal's wife finally asked. Strange how easily Perrin could think of Loyal as married. He really went. - Is the male half of the One Power cleared? Loyal told me about it, and I would really like to talk to people. How crazy are they? Am I too hasty with questions?

"They are human, Erit," Elder Haman said, looking over his shoulder. - Everything is fine. They don't think you're in a hurry.

Loyal's ears twitched forward and then back, which amused Perrin. Despite his frequent complaints about people's impatience, Loyal knew a lot about them.

"The well has been cleansed," Perrin said. "And no, Grady and Niald are not insane. They are as reliable and sensible as any man I know.

"I would really like to talk to them," Erit said. - Were they with Dragon when he did it? I would like to question the witnesses.

"Erit is about to write a book," Loyal said proudly. - It can be an addition to my story about Rand. Great idea, isn't it, Perrin? Erit knows a lot about the One Power.

Erit looked into Perrin's eyes again. Perrin cleared his throat.

- That's great, Erith.

Before destroying the bridges, they found those who fell in the battle for the Island. They lost fourteen men, counting a poor Mayenne who died while they were out of the wind. And Bornhald, whose body was never found.

We don't divide the dead into friends and foes, thought Perrin. People laid the bodies in a row - the White Cloaks next to the Two Rivers, the Mayens next to the Gaeldans. Perrin was proud of it, despite the pain of loss.

Grady knelt beside the bodies and raised his hand.

- Objections? he asked the onlookers.

Everyone was silent. Grady put on a focused expression, then scorched the bodies with powerful Force-created fire that blasted back the darkness of the paths, shining as brightly as the light of a beacon. Perrin approached, feeling the heat of the fire on his skin.

"Our first losses in this war," he said. - And let them not be the last, every death means something important. It means that we will not let the darkness overcome us. Rest in the Light, my friends.

Galad nodded, and his white cloak reminded Perrin of what Bornhald looked like running into the darkness. What he said... was he involved in the death of the Perrin family?

Burn me Light, Perrin thought, feeling old wounds open inside him. It felt so good to blame your losses on the Trollocs. Trollocs were faceless monsters and it was easy to hate them. But Bornhald's words implied that the fault lay not with the Trollocs, but with Padan Fein.

Perrin already hated Fane. Could he hate him more? Will it be of any use? The flame of the funeral pyre burned low. His fury meant that only ashes remained, mixed with bits of metal. Perrin was about to turn away when Elder Haman lunged forward. The old ogier walked straight up to the ash heap, then knelt down and placed something between them.

"Loyal, if you wish," he said.

Kneeling beside the Elder, Loyal sang in a low voice. His eyes were closed in concentration. Another ogier sang nearby. There were no words in the song, and it resembled the one they sang before, although it was clearly different from it. Moments later, the seed sprouted, and a small tree rose from the ashes of the fallen. Loyal opened his eyes.

"I'm sorry it's so small," the Ogier said. I am not as experienced in this matter as I should be. How much better I get glorified wood.

"It will come, Loyal," Elder Haman said. "This place was once ours." His deep voice became menacing. "It was a gift from the Aes Sedai, the last grandiose work of men. If the rumors are true, then the male Aes Sedai have returned.

"We don't call ourselves that," Grady said. - But we're back.

"Then we will restore this place," the elder said. - They gave it to us. We must be sure that we will have power over it, for it belongs to us. As soon as this battle is over, human, I will return here and see that this place is restored. If you join us. Grady smiled, and Nyald beside him nodded.

"I think we'd like that too, Elder Haman.

"Then the tree will be the symbol of our agreement," said the old ogier. - And if it fades - we will sing it to life.

The other Ogier nodded. Looking at their formidable faces, no one would have guessed how reluctantly they entered this place before. No one would ever know how hard they succumbed to persuasion. Some of these creatures even thought Perrin was crazy for daring to enter here.

Perhaps they should have seen firsthand how their gift was ruined.

- Do you wish to join the Last Battle? Perrin asked them.

"We decided it was our duty," Loyal's mother said.

"Then let's rest," Perrin suggested, "and give my people time to recover from what they've been through." Tomorrow we will move into Cairhien and cut off its Waygate just as we did here. After that, I will immediately lead you into battle. I assure you that every ax will be appreciated.

P.S

One of my goals in the last book (which became three books) of the Wheel of Time was to uncover the story of the Paths. There was not much information in Mr. Jordan's notes on how to achieve this, but I felt that the text of the earlier books implied that this line would eventually come to a head.

I found such an opportunity in the need to prevent the enemy from using the Paths. Closing the Caemlyn Waygate made logistical and tactical sense. Back in the early drafts, I planned for Perrin and his squad to go to the Paths, and I could leave some hints about how the Paths could eventually be cleared.

The scene went through quite a bit of proofreading, so I received extensive comments on the revision of the scene from Harriet, Robert Jordan's widow and editor of all the Wheel of Time books, and his assistants Maria and Alan. However, the scene never went through final editing, so we decided to cut it out of the novel. Why? Well, there are two reasons.

Problem One: Narrative Continuity and Atmosphere

This scene with the Paths came out a bit rushed during the first drafts, and therefore didn't convey the right feel and didn't have the atmosphere of previous visits to the Paths. In fact, I didn't even quite remember how rough that piece was. I thought I could get it cleaned in a couple of days of work, but it took almost two full weeks to get it in order.

There were also many small but important continuity issues. We weren't sure if Perrin would be able to navigate the Ways without an ogir guide. I think it was Maria who suggested we use the Black Sisters' notes. After all, even if Trollocs walk the Paths, there must be fairly simple instructions somewhere.

But even with this edit, the problems with this part were still present. For example, in the original version, they destroyed the Way Gate, which was described in the first books as almost impossible. In this edition, I corrected many of these problems using extensive editorial notes, but even then it may have required several more drafts before the scene was worthy of publication in the final book. The second problem, however, turned out to be more serious.

Problem Two: Storytelling and Regression

While editing the Memory of Light, we often wondered if we looked back too often? We wanted the book to be about the battles at Merrilor Field and at Shayol Ghul. The idea was that we wanted to look ahead, not to slow down and not be distracted by any "side stories".

This scene was constantly flagged as "regressive" - it wasn't right to turn the reader's eye to The Ways (who were unimportant for the rest of the book) and Caemlyn (who had already fallen and shouldn't have been the focus after the prologue)

In the end, Harriet decided that the scene needed to be removed. We just couldn't afford 20,000 to 25,000 words about Perrin running off on his own mission in the middle of the book. This was especially true when it became clear that it would take a lot of time and edits to fix the scene - a scene that ended up being nothing more than a departure from the main plot. The tactic was smart, but in the end there was a lot the characters could do, so this particular moment wasn't particularly important.

Harriet was right and the scene should have been removed. However, it upsets me, because I like what happens in it. I like the death of Bornhald. I love the interplay between the characters and the way they come together, as well as the echoes of the early books. My favorite scene is the scene where the Ogiers appear. In the final, published version of the Memory of Light, they entered Merillor's field with little fanfare, a necessity brought in by removal.

Of all the main characters, Robert Jordan's notes are the least descriptive of what to do with Perrin. However, one of the things he said was that Perrin was to become king. I love how this scene, better than most in the published book, shows that Perrin actually managed to do something incredible - to unite disparate ideologies and ethnic groups to form a cohesive squad. I love how it resonates with the other main characters. Perrin is most suited to rule because he is capable of both building and destroying.

I would like to find a solution and refine the Paths so that they do not distract the reader. They were a vital and interesting part of the series, but ended up being ignored.

In the end, I still believe that Harriet made the right decision by cutting the scene, but I hope this post will be able to suggest an ending for one of the pattern's threads hanging in the air.

Brandon Sanderson.